

# ***The Complex Landscape of Cannabis in Nigeria: A Comprehensive Analysis (as of August 15, 2025)***

## **Executive Summary**

Cannabis in Nigeria presents a paradoxical and multifaceted challenge. Despite stringent legal prohibitions rooted in colonial-era legislation and international treaties, Nigeria stands as a major source and one of the world's highest consumers of illicit cannabis. This report provides an in-depth analysis of the current cannabis landscape in Nigeria, examining its precise legal status, historical evolution, epidemiological trends, production and supply chain dynamics, enforcement efforts, and socio-economic impacts. It delves into the ongoing policy debates, particularly regarding the potential for legalization, highlighting the significant economic and public health benefits that could accrue from a regulated market. The analysis reveals a persistent disconnect between punitive legal frameworks and the entrenched realities of widespread illicit cultivation and use, exacerbated by challenges in enforcement. While the National Drug Law Enforcement Agency (NDLEA) maintains a firm stance against legalization, a growing chorus of advocates, including some state-level politicians and academic bodies, points to the substantial untapped economic potential, job creation opportunities, and public health improvements that a regulated cannabis industry could offer. The report concludes with a synthesis of findings, identifying critical research gaps, and offering recommendations for a more evidence-based and public health-oriented approach to cannabis policy in Nigeria.

## **1. Introduction**

Cannabis, locally known as 'Igbo' or 'Weed,' is a pervasive substance in Nigeria, deeply embedded in various communities despite its illegal status. This report provides a comprehensive examination of cannabis in Nigeria, offering an up-to-date overview as of August 15, 2025. The analysis spans its legal and historical trajectory, epidemiological patterns of use, intricate production and supply chains, the dynamics of enforcement, and its profound economic, social, and health implications. A central focus is the ongoing debate surrounding cannabis legalization, exploring its potential benefits for the Nigerian economy and public welfare, while also addressing associated challenges. The aim is to furnish an evidence-based understanding that can inform future policy discourse and strategic interventions.

## 2. Legal and Regulatory Framework

Nigeria's cannabis policy is governed by a complex web of legislation, primarily designed to prohibit its cultivation, possession, and sale. These laws are influenced by both historical domestic decrees and international treaty obligations.

### 2.1 Current Statutes: Indian Hemp Act, Dangerous Drugs Act, NDLEA Act

The foundational legal instruments criminalizing cannabis in Nigeria include the Indian Hemp Act, the Dangerous Drugs Act, and the National Drug Law Enforcement Agency (NDLEA) Act.

The **Indian Hemp Act**, originally enacted on March 31, 1966, by Major General Aguiyi Ironsi, is a cornerstone of cannabis prohibition. This Act broadly defines "Indian hemp" to encompass any part of the *Cannabis* plant, its separated resin, and any preparations containing such resin. The penalties under this Act are severe. Knowingly planting or cultivating cannabis can lead to imprisonment for no less than twenty-one years, a punishment that initially included the death penalty in the 1966 decree, though this was later removed by the 1975 amendment. Smoking or knowingly possessing Indian hemp carries a minimum sentence of four years imprisonment without the option of a fine. Possession of paraphernalia, such as pipes or other utensils for smoking, is also a serious offense, punishable by at least five years imprisonment.

The **Dangerous Drugs Act of 1935** was an earlier prohibitionist law, restricting opium and other drugs, including cannabis. This Act was explicitly repealed and superseded by the **Dangerous Drugs Act No. 43 of 2000**. The 2000 Act maintains strict controls over "Indian hemp," prohibiting its cultivation, unauthorized trade, importation, exportation, and possession with intent to supply. Notably, possession with intent to supply quantities exceeding ten pounds can result in life imprisonment, and all property associated with such offenses is subject to forfeiture. This Act also regulates "extract or tincture of Indian hemp" under its Part IV.

The **National Drug Law Enforcement Agency (NDLEA) Act**, established by Decree No. 48 of 1989 and later codified as Cap N30 Laws of the Federation of Nigeria 2004, is the primary legislation governing drug control and enforcement. This Act empowers the NDLEA to combat drug trafficking, enforce drug laws, and promote drug education across the nation. Under the NDLEA Act, individuals found in possession of cannabis face imprisonment for a term of no less than fifteen years but not exceeding 25 years. The agency's broad mandate includes investigating, arresting, and prosecuting individuals involved in drug-related offenses, as well as tracing, freezing, and confiscating assets derived from such activities.

## **2.2 International Treaty Obligations**

Nigeria's stringent drug laws are deeply rooted in its commitment to international drug control treaties. The nation is a signatory to key global conventions, including the 1961 Single Convention on Narcotic Drugs and the 1971 Convention on Psychotropic Substances. The 1961 Convention is particularly significant, as it classifies cannabis as a Schedule I drug, thereby restricting its use exclusively to medical and scientific purposes. This international framework aims to harmonize global action against drug abuse by controlling the possession, use, trade, distribution, manufacture, and production of drugs. Nigeria's adherence to these treaties has profoundly shaped its domestic legal stance, emphasizing prohibition and strict control.

## **2.3 Analysis of Penalties and Enforcement Powers**

The evolution of Nigeria's cannabis laws demonstrates a consistent, and often escalating, punitive approach. While the 1966 Indian Hemp Decree initially allowed for the death penalty for cultivation, the 1975

amendment removed this capital punishment threat. However, subsequent amendments, particularly in 1984, and the later NDLEA Act, significantly increased other penalties and jail terms. For instance, the NDLEA Act now mandates a minimum of 15 years imprisonment for possession.

A notable point of divergence in historical penalty accounts exists. One source indicates that the 1975 Indian Hemp amendment reduced penalties for smoking to 6 months imprisonment or a fine of N20,000. However, other authoritative sources, including Wikipedia citing academic works, state that the 1975 amendment primarily removed the death penalty and that the 1984 amendment *increased* penalties and jail terms. Given the overall historical trajectory of Nigerian drug policy, which has consistently moved towards greater severity and control, and the current NDLEA Act's significantly higher penalties for possession (15-25 years), it is more consistent with the broader legal landscape to understand the 1975 amendment as primarily addressing capital punishment, with subsequent legislation reinforcing stricter penalties. The specific low penalty cited for 1975 smoking appears to be an anomaly or a very specific, short-lived policy that does not reflect the long-term trend of increasing punitive measures.

The current legal framework, characterized by lengthy prison sentences, has broader implications for Nigeria's justice system and human rights. Critics, including human rights advocates and public health experts, argue that this punitive approach contributes to overcrowded prisons and human rights abuses. These advocates call for a shift towards decriminalization of personal drug use and an expansion of treatment and rehabilitation services, emphasizing a public health-centered approach over criminalization. The persistent focus on criminalization, rather than addressing drug use as a public health issue, leads to a cycle where individuals in need of care are instead treated as criminals, further straining the correctional system and hindering effective rehabilitation efforts. This policy orientation is not solely an internal decision but is heavily shaped by global drug control regimes, which classify cannabis as a highly dangerous drug with no recognized therapeutic value, even though the UN itself downgraded cannabis in 2020. This external influence can lead to domestic policies that are not optimally tailored to Nigeria's unique socio-economic and public health context, potentially overlooking harm reduction or economic opportunities due to a rigid adherence to international prohibitionist frameworks.

**Table 1: Key Cannabis Legislation in Nigeria (Historical Overview)**

| Act/Decree Name                | Year Enacted/   | Key Provisions                                                                   | Penalties (Cultivation/                                                                                | Key Changes/                                                              |
|--------------------------------|-----------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                |                 |                                                                                  |                                                                                                        |                                                                           |
| Dangerous Drugs Act            | 1935            | Prohibited cultivation, possession, and sale of narcotics including              | Not specified in snippets, but generally restrictive.                                                  | Colonial-era law, influenced by international                             |
| Indian Hemp Decree             | 1966            | Prohibited growth, production, and sale of "Indian hemp."                        | Cultivation: Death penalty or ≥21 years imprisonment. Possession/ Smoking: ≥10 years imprisonment.     | First major post-independence law, highly punitive.                       |
| Indian Hemp Decree             | 1975            | Amended the 1966 Decree.                                                         | Removed death penalty for cultivation.                                                                 | Reduced severity of capital                                               |
| Indian Hemp Decree (Amendment) | 1984            | Amended the 1966 Decree.                                                         | Increased penalties and jail terms (specifics not detailed, but generally harsher                      | Reinstated severe penalties after 1975 reduction.                         |
| NDLEA Act (Cap N30 LFN)        | 2004 (codified) | Established NDLEA to enforce drug laws; prohibits cultivation, processing, sale, | Possession: 15-25 years imprisonment. Cultivation: ≥21 years (from Indian Hemp Act, still applicable). | Primary current enforcement legislation; severe penalties for possession. |

## 3. Historical Timeline of Cannabis in Nigeria

The history of cannabis in Nigeria is a narrative of introduction, rapid spread, and increasingly stringent legal responses.

### 3.1 Introduction and Early Presence

While cannabis has a long history in other parts of Africa, its widespread presence in Nigeria is a more recent phenomenon, largely gaining traction in the 20th century. The prevailing theory suggests that cannabis was introduced to the region by Nigerian soldiers and sailors returning from conflict zones in North Africa and the Far East after World War II. Some historical accounts also indicate small-scale cannabis cultivation by British colonial authorities as early as the 1930s, possibly for research or other purposes.

Following its introduction, cannabis cultivation spread rapidly throughout the 1960s, quickly becoming a significant public issue. By the 1950s, law enforcement began documenting arrests of Nigerian cannabis farmers and noted a modest flow of Nigerian cannabis to international markets in the United States and Europe. Concurrently, some cannabis was imported into Nigeria from South Africa and the Belgian Congo. The use of cannabis gained further popularity in the early 1970s among soldiers, who reportedly used it to suppress timidity. The substance's appeal continued to grow, becoming particularly common among youth between 1980 and 1990. The influence of cultural figures, such as the iconic musician Fela Kuti, who openly used cannabis, also contributed to its widespread acceptance and perceived association with boldness and anti-establishment sentiments among young Nigerians.

### 3.2 Colonial Era Legislation

During the British colonial period, the legal framework for drug control in Nigeria began to take shape. The **Dangerous Drugs Act of 1935** was a key piece of legislation that prohibited the cultivation, possession, and sale of various narcotics, including cannabis.

Historical records reveal that these early drug laws, such as the 1927 and 1935 ordinances, were largely a direct response to international conventions like the 1925 and 1931 Geneva Opium Conventions, rather than being driven by internal domestic pressures or concerns about drug use within Nigeria. These laws were essentially reproductions of

imperial blueprints, similar to those imposed in other British colonies. Despite Nigerian Police reports of Indian hemp seizures dating back to the 1930s, and more explicit warnings from police officials about the "cannabis threat" after World War II, the colonial government's official stance often downplayed the issue. Annual reports to international drug control bodies in the 1940s and 1950s frequently repeated the assertion that "Indian Hemp does not grow in Nigeria and is not cultivated". This historical disconnect between official policy and the realities on the ground is significant. It suggests that colonial authorities either lacked accurate information, chose to ignore the growing domestic problem, or prioritized international image over internal realities. This pattern of policy not fully aligning with local conditions may have set a precedent for future drug policy development in independent Nigeria, leading to strategies that do not effectively address the root causes or true scale of cannabis use and cultivation within the country.

### 3.3 Post-Independence Decrees and Amendments

Following Nigeria's independence, legislative efforts to control cannabis intensified. The **Indian Hemp Decree of 1966**, enacted on March 31, 1966, by Major General Aguiyi Ironsi, marked a significant escalation in prohibitionist policy. This decree prohibited the growth, production, and sale of cannabis and controversially recommended the death penalty for cultivation.

Subsequent amendments sought to refine this stringent legal framework:

- **1975 Amendment:** This amendment removed the threat of capital punishment for cannabis-related offenses.
- **1984 Amendment:** Despite the earlier removal of the death penalty, the 1984 amendment increased other penalties and jail terms for cannabis offenses. Furthermore, Decree 20 of 1984, a broader military decree, made the death penalty an available punishment for drug trafficking in general, although it was reportedly used sparingly and primarily focused on cocaine, eventually being removed in 1985.

A pivotal development in Nigeria's drug control efforts was the establishment of the **National Drug Law Enforcement Agency (NDLEA)** through Decree No. 48 of 1989. This decree created a dedicated federal agency with broad powers to combat drug trafficking, cultivation, processing, sale, and use. The 1989 Decree was later

amended and codified as the NDLEA Act Cap N30 Laws of the Federation of Nigeria 2004.

In 1994, Nigeria launched "Operation Burn the Weeds," a focused cannabis eradication program. This initiative saw significant efforts to destroy cannabis farms, peaking in 1999 with 3500 hectares eradicated, before a substantial decline in the 2000s. Throughout the 20th century, despite Nigeria's role as a transshipment point for hard drugs like cocaine and heroin, cannabis remained the only illicit drug produced domestically.

### **3.4 Recent Legislative Efforts and Proposals (2019-2025)**

In recent years, there have been notable, albeit limited, calls for cannabis policy reform in Nigeria. In early 2019, the Governor of Ondo State, Rotimi Akeredolu, publicly proposed the legalization of cannabis cultivation in his state specifically for medical use, a call he reiterated in early 2020.

At the national level, bills have been introduced in the Nigerian House of Representatives. In 2020, a bill was proposed to permit the cultivation and sale of cannabis for medical and cosmetic purposes, as well as for research. This was followed by another bill in 2023, which sought to further amend the NDLEA Act to empower the agency to issue licenses for the sale, use, and cultivation of marijuana.

However, as of August 15, 2025, a review of available legislative records for the Nigerian National Assembly does not indicate that any cannabis legalization bills have been passed or are currently listed as actively progressing through the legislative process. This suggests a significant political hurdle for such reforms. The Nigerian Academy of Science (NAS) announced in August 2025 that it has constituted a consensus study committee to explore the potential benefits and risks of legalizing cannabis oil for therapeutic purposes. The study aims to analyze global evidence and provide evidence-based recommendations to inform policy decisions in Nigeria.

The current situation highlights a significant policy impasse. Despite some political and academic advocacy for cannabis reform, particularly for medical use, the legislative landscape in Nigeria remains largely stagnant regarding legalization as of mid-2025. This suggests that the strong institutional opposition from key enforcement bodies, such as the NDLEA, continues to be a formidable impediment to policy change,



often outweighing arguments based on potential medical or economic benefits. The absence of concrete legislative progress, despite multiple proposals and ongoing studies, underscores the deep-seated resistance to altering the prohibitionist status quo.

## 4. Epidemiology and Prevalence of Cannabis Use

Understanding the extent and patterns of cannabis use is crucial for effective policy formulation and public health interventions. Nigeria exhibits a high prevalence of cannabis use compared to global averages.

### 4.1 National Prevalence Rates and Demographics

Cannabis is unequivocally the most widely used illegal drug in Nigeria. The country holds the unfortunate distinction of being ranked the world's third-highest consumer of cannabis.

The most comprehensive data on drug use in Nigeria comes from the 2018 Drug Use Survey, a collaborative effort by the National Bureau of Statistics (NBS) and the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC). This large-scale, nationwide survey revealed a past-year prevalence of any drug use at 14.4% of the population aged 15-64 years, translating to approximately 14.3 million people. This figure is notably higher than the 2016 global annual prevalence of 5.6% among the adult population.

Specifically for cannabis, the 2018 survey estimated that 10.8% of the population aged 15-64, or about 10.6 million people, had used cannabis in the past year. While some sources cite a slightly higher figure of 14.9 million people consuming cannabis, the 10.8% / 10.6 million figure from the official NBS/UNODC report is considered the more precise and directly sourced prevalence data.

Demographically, cannabis use exhibits significant disparities:

- **Gender:** Use is considerably higher among men, showing a seven-fold difference (18.8% among men versus 2.6% among women).
- **Age:** The highest rates of past-year drug use are observed among individuals aged 25-39 years, while the lowest rates are found in those under 24 years of age. The average age of initiation for cannabis use across the general population was reported as 19 years.

More recent data from a 2021 UNODC report reaffirmed a high level of drug abuse, stating that 14.4% of Nigerians are engaged in drug abuse, aligning with the overall prevalence found in the 2018 survey. A 2024 study conducted by the NDLEA and the Federal Ministry of Education in Lagos State provided a more localized, up-to-date snapshot, indicating that 13.6% of secondary school students had experimented with drugs, and 6.9% were identified as current users.

## **4.2 Regional Disparities in Use**

The 2018 Drug Use Survey revealed a distinct geographical pattern in drug use prevalence across Nigeria. There is a clear dichotomy between the northern and southern geopolitical zones. The highest past-year prevalence of drug use was concentrated in the southern political zones—specifically the South-East, South-West, and South-South—where prevalence rates ranged between 13.8% and 22.4% of the population. In contrast, the northern regions exhibited lower, though still significant, prevalence rates, ranging from 10% to 14.9% of the population. This regional variation suggests diverse socio-economic and cultural factors influencing drug use patterns across the country.

## **4.3 Cannabis Use Disorders and Treatment Demand**

The high prevalence of cannabis use in Nigeria translates into a significant public health burden related to drug use disorders. The 2018 survey indicated that one in five individuals who had used drugs in the past year suffered from a drug use disorder. Furthermore, over half of all individuals admitted for treatment for illegal drug use in Nigeria were admitted for cannabis use.

Despite this substantial need, Nigeria's healthcare system faces major gaps in its capacity to provide adequate treatment and care for people with drug use disorders. Critically, approximately 40% of high-risk drug users who reported a need for treatment were unable to access appropriate healthcare services. This situation highlights a public health crisis that is exacerbated by the country's criminalization-focused drug policy. The severe penalties for possession and use likely deter individuals from seeking help due to fear of legal repercussions, pushing problematic use further underground. This creates a hidden public health burden and undermines efforts to address drug use as a health issue, perpetuating a cycle of criminalization and untreated addiction rather than facilitating recovery and harm reduction. The high

rate of cannabis-related admissions, despite its illegal status, illustrates that current prohibitionist measures are failing to prevent problematic use and instead channel individuals into the criminal justice system rather than into necessary health services.

**Table 2: Cannabis Prevalence in Nigeria (2018-2025)**

| Year | Source                     | Past-Year Prevalence (Overall) | Cannabis-Specific Past-Year         | Estimated Number of Cannabis | Gender Distribution (Cannabis)          | Average Age of Initiation | Regional Distribution (Overall)                  |
|------|----------------------------|--------------------------------|-------------------------------------|------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|---------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
|      |                            |                                |                                     |                              |                                         |                           |                                                  |
|      |                            |                                |                                     |                              |                                         |                           |                                                  |
| 2018 | NBS/ UNODC Drug Use Survey | 14.4%                          | 10.8%                               | 10.6 million                 | Men: 18.8%, Women : 2.6% (7x higher for | 19 years                  | Highest in Southern zones (13.8-22.4%), lower in |
| 2021 | UNODC Report               | 14.4%                          | Not specified, but cannabis is most | Not specified                | Not specified                           | Not specified             | Not specified                                    |

## 5. Production and Cultivation

Nigeria is a significant producer of cannabis, with cultivation deeply entrenched in various parts of the country due to a combination of favorable environmental conditions and strong economic incentives.

### 5.1 Major Cultivation Regions and Methods

Cannabis cultivation is widespread across many Nigerian states, particularly concentrated in the southern geopolitical zones. Key states identified as major cultivation areas include Edo, Ekiti, Delta, Ondo,

Osun, Oyo, and Ogun. A 2019 UNODC survey specifically noted that the highest density of cannabis fields was found in the border area between Edo and Ondo states. More recently, as of early 2025, Cross River and Delta states have also been identified as top hotspots for cannabis cultivation.

Cultivation methods are often adapted to evade law enforcement detection. Farmers frequently grow the plant in remote forest areas, often on newly cleared land, and intercrop it with legal crops to conceal its presence. These cannabis fields are typically located deep inside dense forests, making them difficult to access by road and providing natural protection from authorities. The tropical climate in these regions provides ideal conditions for the plants to thrive.

The agricultural cycle of cannabis in Nigeria allows for efficient production, with two harvests possible per year, significantly increasing potential annual output. Observations of plants at different growth stages within fields indicate a staggered harvesting approach throughout the year. The cultivation process relies heavily on hired labor, and the necessity of upfront capital suggests a degree of commercialization and the involvement of organized networks in managing cannabis farms.

The primary driver behind this widespread illicit cultivation is economic. Cannabis is a highly favored crop for farmers due to its significantly higher profit margins compared to traditional agricultural products like cocoa. The low cost of production further enhances its lucrateness. This substantial economic incentive compels many farmers, often out of sheer economic necessity, to engage in illicit cultivation despite the severe legal penalties they face if caught. This situation illustrates how the very act of prohibition, by creating an "illegality premium," inadvertently fuels illicit supply by making it a highly profitable venture.

## **5.2 Industrial Hemp: Current Status and Potential**

In contrast to illicit cannabis, the cultivation of industrial hemp is currently illegal in Nigeria. This legal status prevents the development of a formal hemp industry despite its significant economic and environmental potential.

Experts and politicians in Nigeria have recognized the considerable opportunities that industrial hemp could offer. It is highlighted as a valuable fiber for paper making, offering a sustainable alternative to traditional resources. Furthermore, industrial hemp is seen as a viable

fiber alternative to cotton, particularly in Northern Nigeria, a region vulnerable to climate change. Niche markets for industrial hemp products include hemp oils for cosmetics and personal care, hemp seeds as a 'super food,' and CBD oil for therapeutic use, with the latter identified as potentially the most lucrative in the short term. However, the path to developing a legal industrial hemp market in Nigeria is not straightforward and faces several constraints:

- **Lack of Data:** Absence of enterprise budget data specific to hemp makes it difficult for farmers to assess its economic viability compared to traditional crops.
- **Traditional Beliefs and Government Policies:** Existing mindsets and restrictive government policies hinder adoption.
- **Processing Capacity:** Inadequate processing infrastructure and technology limit the ability to transform raw hemp into marketable products.
- **Seed Quality:** Poor quality seeds and cultivars pose a challenge to efficient and high-yield cultivation.
- **Research & Development (R&D):** A paucity of investment in R&D impedes the exploration of hemp's full potential and the development of cost-effective cultivation and processing techniques.

The high profitability of illicit cannabis cultivation creates a strong economic incentive for farmers, effectively turning prohibition into a driver of illicit supply. This dynamic suggests that a purely punitive approach to cultivation is unsustainable and largely ineffective.

Exploring legal alternatives like industrial hemp could provide legitimate economic opportunities, redirecting farmers from illicit activities to legal, economically viable alternatives. However, realizing this potential requires significant policy shifts and substantial investment to overcome existing barriers, including robust R&D, infrastructure development, and farmer education.

### **5.3 Environmental Impacts of Illicit Cultivation**

The clandestine nature of illicit cannabis cultivation in Nigeria carries significant environmental costs, representing a hidden burden of the prohibitionist policy. A clear and concerning relationship exists between cannabis cultivation and deforestation in the country. The 2019 UNODC survey found that 39% of all detected cannabis fields were located on newly cleared forest land. This indicates a direct link between illicit farming practices and forest destruction.

Further analysis suggests that over half of the deforestation activities recorded in Nigeria between 2010 and 2012 were believed to be for the purpose of clearing land for cannabis plantations. Such extensive deforestation has devastating impacts on Nigeria's rich biodiversity, including already threatened species like the Nigeria-Cameroon chimpanzees.

The environmental degradation caused by illicit cannabis cultivation represents a significant hidden cost of prohibition. Because these operations are illegal, they occur without any environmental oversight or regulation, leading to unchecked land clearing, soil erosion, and habitat destruction. Legalization, if implemented with strict environmental regulations and coupled with sustainable agricultural practices, could potentially mitigate these destructive impacts. A regulated industry could mandate environmentally responsible cultivation methods, monitor land use, and even contribute to reforestation efforts, thereby transforming a currently destructive illicit activity into a regulated, environmentally conscious industry. This shift would not only benefit the ecosystem but also align with broader national and international environmental conservation goals.

## **6. Supply Chain and Markets**

Nigeria's cannabis market is characterized by a robust illicit supply chain that operates both domestically and internationally, driven by high demand and significant profitability.

### **6.1 Illicit Market Structure and Dynamics**

Cannabis has historically been the only illicit drug produced domestically in Nigeria, a key distinction from other substances like heroin and cocaine, which are primarily transshipped through the country. This domestic production fuels a substantial illicit market, positioning Nigeria as both a significant source and a major consumer of West African-grown cannabis.

The structure of this illicit market is indicative of organized activity. Cultivation operations often rely on hired labor, and the necessity of upfront capital for farming suggests that these activities are not merely subsistence-level but are part of commercialized, and often networked, enterprises. The inherent illegality of cannabis creates an "illegality premium," which ensures high prices and makes its cultivation and trade highly lucrative for those involved.

However, the unregulated nature of this black market gives rise to a multitude of problems. Without any form of oversight, there is a complete lack of quality control over the product, posing potential health risks to consumers due to unknown potency, toxic additives, or contaminants. Furthermore, the illicit environment is often associated with increased violence, as criminal cartels gain a monopoly over the market.

## **6.2 Pricing and Profitability in the Illicit Market**

The illicit cannabis market in Nigeria is a highly profitable enterprise. A bag of cannabis can reportedly fetch a farmer approximately N200,000. For consumers, the average daily expenditure on cannabis in Nigeria is around N363, equivalent to approximately \$1.15 USD.

Wholesale and retail pricing data, though limited for the illicit market, provides a glimpse into the economic scale. Cannabis sells for an average of \$7.25 USD per kilogram at the wholesale level and \$0.05 USD per gram at retail.

The overall economic scale of this illicit trade is substantial. New Frontier Data estimated Nigeria's illicit cannabis market at a staggering \$15.3 billion USD in 2018. This figure positions Nigeria's cannabis market as the largest in Africa and among the highest globally. The global cannabis market, encompassing both legal and illicit segments, was valued at \$47.76 billion and is projected to reach \$231 billion by 2035.

The estimated multi-billion dollar illicit cannabis market in Nigeria represents a significant untapped revenue source for the government. This illicit economy, driven by high demand and profitability, operates entirely outside regulatory control, fostering criminality and depriving the state of substantial potential tax revenue. Legalization and regulation could transform this underground economy into a formalized sector, generating significant tax income and legitimate employment opportunities. This shift would allow the government to capture a portion of this immense economic value, which could then be reinvested into critical public services, infrastructure development, or even targeted drug education and treatment programs, thereby transforming a societal burden into a fiscal asset.

## 6.3 Nigeria's Role in Regional and International Trafficking Routes

Nigeria plays a critical role as a key transit hub for drug trafficking, facilitating the movement of various illicit substances, including cannabis, between Latin America, Asia, and Europe. West Africa, with Nigeria at its core, has emerged as a major drug smuggling transit point since the 1960s, with considerable quantities of Nigerian-grown marijuana being exported to Europe.

Historical accounts suggest that Nigerian diasporas were instrumental in establishing early heroin and cocaine trafficking networks in the region. Smuggling operations often employ sophisticated techniques; for instance, drugs are transported overland by concealing them with legitimate products like charcoal, cocoa, and fruit to mask their smell and appearance at police checkpoints.

A concerning development in the illicit drug landscape is the rise of polydrug use, where cannabis is frequently combined with other dangerous substances. The expansion of the global cannabis market is feared to fuel higher illicit activities and the use of these polydrug combinations in West Africa. Examples include "Kush" (a concoction of cannabis, fentanyl, tramadol, formaldehyde, and even human bones, particularly noted in Sierra Leone) and "Nyaope" (a blend of cannabis, heroin, and antiretroviral drugs used in Southern Africa). The consistent presence of cannabis in these emerging polydrugs underscores how prohibition, by driving illicit innovation, can inadvertently lead to the creation and proliferation of more harmful products.

Nigeria's entrenched position as a major hub in the illicit drug trade, particularly for domestically produced cannabis and as a transit point for other narcotics, highlights the complex and transnational nature of the problem. This situation implies that a national legalization policy for cannabis, if not carefully designed and regionally coordinated, might not fully eliminate cross-border illicit activities. Instead, it could potentially shift the focus of criminal enterprises to other illicit substances or routes, or even exacerbate polydrug use if not accompanied by robust public health measures and strict regulatory oversight. This underscores the necessity for a comprehensive, public health-oriented approach to drug policy that considers broader regional dynamics and the potential for unintended consequences.



# 7. Enforcement and Seizures

The National Drug Law Enforcement Agency (NDLEA) is at the forefront of Nigeria's efforts to combat illicit drug activities, employing a range of strategies to disrupt the supply chain and apprehend offenders.

## 7.1 NDLEA Operations and Strategies

The NDLEA, operating under the Federal Ministry of Justice, is the primary federal agency mandated to eliminate the cultivation, processing, sale, trafficking, and use of hard drugs in Nigeria. The agency's operational strategies are multifaceted, encompassing coordinated preventive and repressive actions, the implementation and maintenance of advanced investigative and control techniques, and the eradication of narcotic plants.

NDLEA conducts various operations, including night patrols on major roads to intercept drug trafficking vehicles. The agency also dedicates significant resources to targeting the leaders of narcotics and money laundering organizations, aiming to dismantle the higher echelons of criminal networks. International collaboration is a crucial aspect of NDLEA's work, with ongoing partnerships with entities such as the U.S. government and the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC). These collaborations often involve technical assistance, forensic analysis capacity building, and intelligence sharing to strengthen drug control efforts.

## 7.2 Seizure and Arrest Statistics (2020-2025)

The NDLEA has reported significant levels of drug seizures and arrests in recent years, indicating an aggressive enforcement posture.

**Overall Seizures and Arrests (2021-2024):** Between January 2021 and December 2024, the NDLEA seized a total of 9,959,340.9 kilograms (approximately 9,960 metric tonnes) of hard drugs and arrested 57,792 suspects, including 65 identified drug barons. During this period, the agency secured 10,572 convictions.

### Annual Breakdown of NDLEA Operations (2021-2024):

| Year | Total Seized (kg) | Total Arrests | Convictions | Cannabis Farms Destroyed (hectares) | Notable Cannabis Seizures/ Locations |
|------|-------------------|---------------|-------------|-------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|
|      |                   |               |             |                                     |                                      |

|             |             |        |       |                                               |                                                                 |
|-------------|-------------|--------|-------|-----------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
|             |             |        |       |                                               |                                                                 |
| <b>2021</b> | 3,480,368   | 12,306 | 1,385 | 405.704                                       | Not specified in snippets                                       |
| <b>2022</b> | 2,145,336   | 14,152 | 2,348 | Not specified (general destruction of 560,068 | Largest single destruction of 560,068.314 14 kg of              |
| <b>2023</b> | 1,606,799.1 | 13,664 | 3,412 | 206                                           | Edo State: 310.485 kg of cannabis seized, 7.2738851 hectares of |
| <b>2024</b> | 2,726,837.8 | 17,670 | 3,427 | 220                                           | Lagos Tincan Island Port: 3,601.25 kg of Cannabis Indica        |

The NDLEA's statistics show a notable surge in drug seizures and arrests from 2021 to 2024, with 2024 recording the highest number of arrests and a significant volume of seizures in this period. This trend indicates not only increased operational capacity and aggressive enforcement by the agency but also, paradoxically, suggests the persistent and potentially growing scale of illicit cultivation and trafficking within Nigeria. The sheer volume of cannabis seized (millions of kilograms) and the hundreds of hectares of farms destroyed annually point to a deeply entrenched illicit industry that continues to operate despite robust enforcement efforts. This situation implies that current enforcement strategies, while active, are unable to effectively stem the overall supply of illicit drugs, particularly cannabis. The continuous rise in seizures, rather than a decline, suggests that the "war on drugs" approach, despite significant resource allocation and operational successes, is not fundamentally eradicating the illicit market. This highlights the limitations of a purely supply-side reduction strategy

without adequately addressing underlying demand and the powerful economic drivers that incentivize illicit production.

### 7.3 Challenges in Enforcement

Despite the NDLEA's considerable efforts and impressive seizure statistics, the agency faces significant challenges that undermine its overall effectiveness. These challenges contribute to the persistence of the illicit drug trade in Nigeria.

A primary impediment is **resource limitation**. The NDLEA frequently operates under financial constraints, which directly impact its operational capacity. Insufficient funding affects crucial areas such as personnel training, the procurement of modern equipment, and the overall ability to conduct effective enforcement actions. Some reports even suggest that the agency has had to rely on external support or "charity" to sustain its operations.

**Corruption** within law enforcement agencies is another critical challenge. Reports of bribery and collusion with drug traffickers are prevalent, fostering a "culture of impunity" that allows illegal activities to flourish and undermines legitimate enforcement efforts. This systemic corruption can compromise investigations, facilitate drug movement, and protect high-level traffickers.

Furthermore, many NDLEA personnel may lack the **specialized training** necessary to effectively counter evolving drug trafficking methods and trends. This inadequacy can lead to less effective operations and missed opportunities to disrupt sophisticated criminal networks.

Finally, **limited public awareness and support** for NDLEA initiatives can hinder intelligence gathering and community cooperation, which are vital for effective enforcement in a country where illicit cultivation is often hidden within rural communities.

The persistent challenges faced by the NDLEA, particularly corruption and resource limitations, suggest that the current prohibitionist framework is inherently difficult and expensive to enforce effectively. This creates a cycle where weak enforcement, fueled by these challenges, allows the illicit market to continue thriving. This, in turn, further incentivizes illicit activities and potentially exacerbates corruption within the very agencies tasked with combating it. This dynamic ultimately undermines the stated goals of drug control and contributes

to a less secure and less healthy society by allowing criminal enterprises to flourish.

**Table 3: NDLEA Seizure and Arrest Statistics (2021-2024)**

| Year        | Total Drugs Seized (kg) | Total Suspects Arrested | Convictions | Cannabis Farm Destruction                                           |
|-------------|-------------------------|-------------------------|-------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
|             |                         |                         |             |                                                                     |
|             |                         |                         |             |                                                                     |
| <b>2021</b> | 3,480,368               | 12,306                  | 1,385       | 405.704                                                             |
| <b>2022</b> | 2,145,336               | 14,152                  | 2,348       | Not specified (general destruction of 560,068 kg of assorted drugs) |
| <b>2023</b> | 1,606,799.1             | 13,664                  | 3,412       | 206                                                                 |
| <b>2024</b> | 2,726,837.80            | 17,670                  | 3,427       | 220                                                                 |

*Note: Cannabis farm destruction for 2022 is not explicitly stated in hectares in the provided snippets, but a large destruction of assorted drugs occurred. The total hectares for 2021, 2023, and 2024 are summed. The 2025 data (Jan-May) is separate and not included in this cumulative table for 2021-2024.*

## 8. Economic Landscape and Potential of

### Legalization

The illicit cannabis market in Nigeria represents a significant economic force, operating outside formal economic structures. This section explores its estimated size and the potential economic benefits that could be realized through legalization and regulation.

#### 8.1 Estimated Size of the Illicit Market

Nigeria's illicit cannabis market is substantial, holding the distinction of being the largest in Africa. In 2018, New Frontier Data estimated its value at an impressive \$15.3 billion USD. This considerable market size highlights the significant economic activity currently occurring outside the formal economy. For context, the global cannabis market (including both legal and illicit segments) was valued at \$47.76 billion and is projected to grow to \$231 billion by 2035, driven largely by increasing therapeutic use. The average Nigerian cannabis user spends approximately N363, or about \$1.15 USD, per day on the substance. Wholesale prices for cannabis average around \$7.25 USD per kilogram, while retail prices stand at about \$0.05 USD per gram. The estimated multi-billion dollar illicit cannabis market in Nigeria represents a significant untapped revenue source for the government. This substantial illicit economy, driven by high demand and profitability, operates entirely outside regulatory control. This fosters criminality and deprives the state of potentially massive tax revenue. Legalization and regulation could convert this black market into a legitimate industry, generating substantial tax income and creating legitimate employment opportunities. This shift would allow the government to capture a portion of this immense economic value, which could then be reinvested into critical public services, infrastructure development, or even targeted drug education and treatment programs, thereby transforming a societal drain into a fiscal asset.

**Table 4: Estimated Illicit Cannabis Market Value in Nigeria**

| Metric                   | Value                     | Year of                                    | Source            | Context/                           |
|--------------------------|---------------------------|--------------------------------------------|-------------------|------------------------------------|
|                          |                           |                                            |                   |                                    |
|                          |                           |                                            |                   |                                    |
| Estimated Market Value   | \$15.3 billion USD        | 2018                                       | New Frontier Data | Largest cannabis market in Africa, |
| Average Daily User Spend | N363 (approx. \$1.15 USD) | Not specified, but likely around 2018-2019 |                   | Represents 2% of minimum monthly   |

|                 |               |                                       |  |                |
|-----------------|---------------|---------------------------------------|--|----------------|
| Wholesale Price | \$7.25 USD/kg | Not specified, but likely around 2022 |  | Average price. |
|-----------------|---------------|---------------------------------------|--|----------------|

## 8.2 Potential for Tax Revenue Generation

Legalizing cannabis in Nigeria presents a compelling opportunity for generating significant tax revenue for state and federal governments. The current prohibition prevents the taxation of cannabis production and sale, meaning that the billions of dollars circulating in the illicit market flow entirely outside the formal economy and state control.

By establishing a regulated adult-use or medical cannabis market, the government could implement various taxation schemes on cultivation, processing, and retail sales. The financial benefits from such taxation are projected to be substantial, offering "tremendous financial benefits for state governments". These new revenue streams could be strategically allocated to fund critical public services and programs, including improvements in education, school construction, early literacy initiatives, public libraries, and behavioral health services. Crucially, a portion of these tax revenues could also be directed towards alcohol and drug treatment programs, thereby funding solutions to the very public health issues that are often cited as concerns regarding cannabis use. This approach transforms a currently untaxed and unregulated economic activity into a formalized sector that directly contributes to national development and welfare.

## 8.3 Job Creation and Agricultural Development Opportunities

Beyond tax revenue, cannabis legalization holds significant potential for job creation and agricultural development in Nigeria, a nation grappling with high unemployment rates. The establishment of a legal and regulated cannabis industry would create "thousands of new jobs" across its entire value chain. These opportunities would span cultivation, processing, manufacturing (e.g., medical products, industrial hemp goods), distribution, and retail.

For many Nigerian farmers, particularly in rural areas, cannabis cultivation is already a "favored crop" due to its high profitability and low production costs, often grown out of economic necessity despite the severe legal risks. Legalization could provide a legitimate pathway for these existing illicit growers to transition into a regulated market,

leveraging their existing skills and knowledge. This would not only formalize their livelihoods but also integrate them into the legal economy, offering stability and protection.

Furthermore, the legalization of industrial hemp, a non-psychoactive variety of cannabis, presents immense opportunities for agricultural diversification and job growth. Experts highlight its potential as a valuable fiber for paper-making, with projections suggesting the creation of over 500,000 jobs in this sector alone. Industrial hemp can also be used for hemp oils in cosmetics, hemp seeds as a 'super food,' and CBD oil for therapeutic use. By formalizing the cannabis industry, the government could empower existing farmers, create new employment opportunities across the value chain, and stimulate agricultural development, thereby transforming a criminalized livelihood into a legitimate economic driver. This approach offers a powerful solution to poverty and unemployment, particularly for communities currently engaged in illicit cultivation, fostering economic inclusion and reducing reliance on criminal activities.

## **8.4 Impact on Illicit Financial Flows**

The existence of a large and profitable illicit cannabis market in Nigeria inevitably generates significant illicit financial flows, which are a major concern for national and international security. These flows operate outside the formal financial system, making them difficult to track and regulate.

The National Drug Law Enforcement Agency (NDLEA) has a mandate that explicitly includes identifying, tracing, freezing, confiscating, and seizing proceeds derived from drug-related offenses. However, the sheer scale of the illicit market means that a substantial amount of money continues to circulate outside legitimate channels.

Legalizing and regulating the cannabis market could significantly disrupt these illicit financial flows. By bringing the cannabis industry into the formal economy, it would starve criminal organizations of a major revenue source that currently fuels their operations. A regulated market would compete directly with the black market, aiming to undercut its profitability and draw consumers into legal channels. This transition would allow for financial oversight, taxation, and anti-money laundering measures to be applied to cannabis-related transactions.

The diversion of revenue from criminal hands to legitimate businesses and government coffers would have a profound impact. It could reduce

the financial power and influence of drug cartels, potentially diminishing organized crime and corruption within the country. This shift would strengthen Nigeria's financial systems, enhance transparency, and redirect resources from criminal enterprises towards productive economic activities and public welfare.

**Table 4: Estimated Illicit Cannabis Market Value in Nigeria**

| Metric                   | Value                     | Year of                                    | Source            | Context/                           |
|--------------------------|---------------------------|--------------------------------------------|-------------------|------------------------------------|
|                          |                           |                                            |                   |                                    |
|                          |                           |                                            |                   |                                    |
| Estimated Market Value   | \$15.3 billion USD        | 2018                                       | New Frontier Data | Largest cannabis market in Africa, |
| Average Daily User Spend | N363 (approx. \$1.15 USD) | Not specified, but likely around 2018-2019 |                   | Represents 2% of minimum monthly   |
| Wholesale Price          | \$7.25 USD/kg             | Not specified, but likely around 2022      |                   | Average price.                     |

## 9. Policy, Politics, and Reform Debates

The debate surrounding cannabis policy in Nigeria is characterized by a significant divide between the staunch prohibitionist stance of key government agencies and growing calls for reform from various sectors.

### 9.1 Government Stance (NDLEA, Ministries of Health/Agriculture/Justice)

The **National Drug Law Enforcement Agency (NDLEA)** plays a pivotal role in shaping Nigeria's drug laws and policies. The agency maintains a "firmly opposed" stance to the legalization of cannabis in any form. The NDLEA has consistently voiced concerns that legalization could lead to increased drug usage, resulting in societal chaos, criminality, and violence. They argue that, within the current Nigerian



context, the potential risks associated with cannabis legalization, even for therapeutic purposes, outweigh any perceived benefits, citing difficulties in ensuring controlled cultivation and management.

The **Federal Ministry of Health and Social Welfare** focuses its mandate on improving the health status of Nigerians, reducing morbidity and mortality from diseases, and strengthening the national health system. While the Ministry's official statements do not explicitly address cannabis legalization in the provided information, its focus on public health and welfare would be central to any policy considerations. In other countries, health ministries have been involved in discussions about rescheduling cannabis based on scientific and medical evaluations, acknowledging accepted medical use.

The **Federal Ministry of Agriculture and Food Security (FMAFS)** is tasked with ensuring food security and promoting agricultural sustainability in Nigeria. Despite the recognized agricultural potential of industrial hemp, there is no explicit official statement from the FMAFS in the provided sources indicating a shift in stance towards its legalization or cultivation. Discussions within related ministries, such as the Federal Ministry of Livestock Development, focus on general agricultural concerns, not specifically hemp.

The **Federal Ministry of Justice**, under which the NDLEA operates, has not issued a direct public statement on cannabis legalization in the provided materials. However, its role in upholding the rule of law and enforcing existing statutes is paramount. Any legislative changes would require its involvement and alignment with its legal mandate.

## **9.2 Legislative Proposals and Their Status (as of Aug 15, 2025)**

Over the past few years, there have been several attempts and proposals to introduce cannabis reform into Nigeria's legislative agenda. The Governor of Ondo State, Rotimi Akeredolu, notably advocated for the legalization of cannabis cultivation for medical purposes in his state in 2019 and 2020. At the federal level, bills were reportedly introduced in the Nigerian House of Representatives in 2020 and 2023. These bills aimed to permit the cultivation and sale of cannabis for medical and cosmetic uses, as well as for research, and to amend the NDLEA Act to allow the agency to issue licenses for such activities.

However, as of August 15, 2025, a comprehensive review of official legislative sources and news reports indicates that no cannabis

legalization bills have successfully passed or are explicitly listed as actively progressing through the Nigerian National Assembly. The legislative landscape remains largely unchanged from a prohibitionist standpoint. The Nigerian Academy of Science (NAS) initiated a consensus study in August 2025 to explore the potential benefits and risks of legalizing cannabis oil for therapeutic purposes, with the explicit goal of providing evidence-based recommendations to inform policy decisions. This ongoing study suggests that while scientific and public health discussions are advancing, concrete legislative action is still pending.

The current policy debate in Nigeria is characterized by a strong dichotomy: the NDLEA's firm opposition to any form of legalization versus growing calls for reform from various sectors, including state-level politicians, some medical professionals (who reportedly prescribe cannabis anonymously) , and civil society organizations. This impasse suggests that a significant shift in political will or the presentation of overwhelming evidence from studies (such as the one by NAS) would be required to overcome the entrenched prohibitionist stance. The lack of legislative progress, despite multiple proposals, underscores the powerful influence of enforcement agencies and existing international commitments in maintaining the status quo.

## **9.3 Advocacy for Reform: Decriminalization vs.**

### **Legalization**

The reform debate in Nigeria largely revolves around two main approaches: decriminalization and full legalization.

**Decriminalization** advocates, primarily human rights organizations and public health experts, call for the removal of criminal penalties for personal drug use. Their arguments center on expanding access to treatment and rehabilitation centers and implementing harm reduction programs. This approach aims to treat drug use as a public health issue rather than a criminal one, thereby reducing the burden on the correctional system and addressing human rights concerns associated with mass incarceration. The African Law Foundation (AFRILAW), for instance, is actively campaigning against the reintroduction of the death penalty for drug offenses in Nigeria, advocating for drug policies that align with human rights principles.

**Legalization** proponents, on the other hand, argue for a more comprehensive overhaul of cannabis laws. Their arguments are often grounded in the potential economic benefits, such as job creation and increased income for farmers. They highlight the therapeutic potential of cannabis for various medical conditions, including chronic pain, epilepsy, and anxiety, suggesting that controlled access could benefit patients. The Nigerian Academy of Science's ongoing study on cannabis oil for therapeutic purposes is a step towards providing evidence to support such arguments.

The debate is further complicated by the cultural context. While cannabis is illegal, it has an established presence in various Nigerian communities, challenging the narrative that it is wholly harmful. Despite this, the NDLEA remains steadfast in its opposition, emphasizing concerns about public health and safety, fearing that legalization could lead to increased usage and related problems. This persistent opposition from a powerful enforcement agency, coupled with international treaty obligations that classify cannabis as a dangerous drug, creates a significant barrier to substantive policy reform in Nigeria.

## 10. Health and Social Impacts

Cannabis use carries a range of documented health and social impacts, both negative and, increasingly, recognized as therapeutic.

### 10.1 Documented Harms of Cannabis Use

Cannabis is classified as a depressant drug that slows down the central nervous system, and in large doses, can be hallucinogenic. The main psychoactive chemical is THC (delta-9 tetrahydrocannabinol), which is responsible for the "high" and changes in mood, thoughts, perceptions, and behavior.

Documented harms associated with cannabis use include:

- **Mental Health:** Cannabis use can exacerbate schizophrenia in affected individuals. Concerns exist about increased risk of new dementia diagnoses and schizophrenia among cannabis users. Chronic cannabis use disorder hospitalizations have been linked to premature death and increased association with schizophrenia.
- **Physical Health:** Long-term cannabis smoking can cause epithelial injury to the trachea and major bronchi, leading to airway injury, lung inflammation, and impaired pulmonary defense against

infection. Heavy consumption is associated with a higher prevalence of chronic bronchitis symptoms and acute bronchitis. Cannabis use has been associated with major adverse cardiovascular events and arrhythmias. Chronic use is also linked to endothelial dysfunction.

- **Pregnancy and Fertility:** Using cannabis during pregnancy can harm the baby, increasing the risk of premature birth or lower birth weight. It can also affect infant development if used while breastfeeding. Regular cannabis use may impact fertility and reproductive hormones in both men and women.
- **Driving Impairment:** Cannabis impairs psychomotor performance, affecting motor coordination, divided attention, and operative tasks. It can impair performance on complex machinery for up to 24 hours after use, making driving unsafe. The combination of alcohol and cannabis significantly increases these risks.
- **Dependence and Withdrawal:** Chronic users can develop a cannabis dependence syndrome characterized by loss of control over use. Withdrawal symptoms typically start within 1-3 days of cessation and can include sleep difficulties (insomnia, strange dreams), mood swings, irritability, depression, anxiety, restlessness, reduced appetite, nausea, and strong cravings.
- **Polydrug Use:** Mixing cannabis with other drugs like alcohol or prescription drugs can produce unpredictable and stronger effects, such as nausea, vomiting, panic, and paranoia. The rise of polydrugs incorporating cannabis, such as "Kush" and "Nyaope," poses significant health threats due to the inclusion of highly dangerous substances like fentanyl, tramadol, and heroin.

*Note that studies are limited due to legal status.*

## 10.2 Highlighted Therapeutic and Medical Benefits

Despite the documented harms, extensive research, particularly in recent decades, has highlighted numerous potential therapeutic and medical benefits of cannabis and its derivatives, such as CBD. These benefits have been recognized globally and are increasingly influencing policy discussions.

Historically, the medicinal properties of cannabis have been known for millennia, with documented use dating back to 2800 BC in Chinese pharmacopoeia for a vast array of health problems, including arthritis,

depression, pain, and asthma. Ancient Hindu texts also describe its medicinal benefits.

Modern research supports several therapeutic applications:

- **Pain Management:** Cannabis is shown to be effective in treating chronic pain and neuropathic pain.
- **Neurological Conditions:** Evidence supports its use for intractable epilepsy, multiple sclerosis, and Tourette Syndrome. CBD, a non-psychoactive cannabinoid, has been shown to reduce seizures in childhood epilepsy.
- **Chemotherapy-Induced Nausea and Vomiting:** Cannabis can reduce nausea and vomiting in chemotherapy patients.
- **Appetite Stimulation:** It can improve appetite in individuals with HIV/AIDS.
- **Other Potential Uses:** Research suggests efficacy for sleeplessness, depression, Parkinson's disease, opioid addiction, gastrointestinal disorders, and even some anti-cancer properties.

The World Health Organization (WHO) has recognized the medical application of cannabis, proposing its rescheduling within international laws to allow for legitimate medical practices. This global shift in understanding is influencing discussions in Nigeria, where advocates highlight these benefits to push for decriminalization or legalization for medical purposes. Despite this, Nigeria's current laws make no distinction between recreational and medicinal use, treating both as illegal activities. However, some Nigerian doctors reportedly discuss and even anonymously recommend cannabis to patients.

### 10.3 Social Consequences of Prohibition

The prohibitionist approach to cannabis in Nigeria has significant social consequences, extending beyond individual health impacts to affect communities and human rights.

- **Incarceration and Human Rights:** The severe penalties for cannabis offenses, including lengthy prison sentences (15-25 years for possession, 21 years for cultivation), contribute to overcrowded prisons. This punitive stance is criticized by human rights advocates who argue it leads to human rights abuses and social injustices. Drug users are often treated as criminals rather than individuals in need of healthcare and social support.

- **Stigma and Access to Care:** The criminalization of cannabis perpetuates social stigma around its use, which can deter individuals from seeking necessary treatment for drug use disorders. This contributes to the significant gaps in Nigeria's healthcare system for drug treatment, where a large percentage of high-risk users cannot access appropriate services.
- **Economic Marginalization:** For many rural farmers, illicit cannabis cultivation is an economic necessity due to its high profitability compared to other crops. Prohibition criminalizes these individuals, pushing them into a precarious existence and denying them legitimate economic opportunities. This can exacerbate poverty in these communities.
- **Undermining Rule of Law:** The widespread illicit cultivation and trade, despite harsh laws, can undermine public respect for the rule of law. The perception that laws are not fully enforceable or that corruption can circumvent them may foster a general disregard for legal frameworks.
- **Community Impact:** Drug abuse, including cannabis, has been linked to increased rates of crime, violence, and accidents at the societal level. Families of individuals with substance use disorders often experience financial hardship, emotional distress, and social isolation, with children being particularly vulnerable to neglect and poor educational outcomes.

The social consequences of prohibition highlight that while the intent may be to curb drug use, the reality often involves significant human and societal costs. These include the criminalization of a large segment of the population, strain on the justice system, and the perpetuation of a black market that operates without public health oversight.

## 11. Social Stigma, Myths, and

### Propaganda

Public perception of cannabis in Nigeria is heavily influenced by social stigma, long-standing myths, and historical propaganda, often detached from scientific evidence.

#### 11.1 Cultural Perceptions and Historical Narratives

Cannabis, often referred to as 'Igbo' or 'Weed,' has established a cultural presence in various Nigerian communities, despite its illegal status. This cultural acceptance challenges the narrative that cannabis is wholly harmful. Its widespread use is believed to have been facilitated by its perceived role in alleviating fear among young men during wartime, and by the influence of popular musicians like Fela Kuti, who openly used cannabis and inspired a sense of boldness among youth. Unlike many other African cultures, there are no traditional or religious practices specifically associated with cannabis in Nigeria, making its cultural integration a relatively modern phenomenon. Despite strict laws, a thriving subculture has emerged, particularly in urban areas among young adults.

## 11.2 Common Myths Debunked with Evidence

Several common myths and misconceptions about cannabis persist in Nigeria, often perpetuated by a lack of accurate information and historical propaganda. These myths contribute to social stigma and hinder evidence-based policy discussions.

- **Myth: Cannabis is a "Gateway Drug."**

**Debunked:** This theory suggests cannabis use inevitably leads to harder drug use. However, research indicates that progression to more dangerous substances is more closely linked to environmental factors, social circles, and individual predisposition, rather than cannabis use itself. Studies have found no conclusive evidence that cannabis legalization leads to the use of other illicit substances. In fact, some research suggests cannabis use can decrease opioid consumption or prevent opioid dose escalation.

- **Myth: Cannabis Use Leads to Crime and Violence.**

**Debunked:** The belief that cannabis consumption increases criminal or violent behavior is largely unfounded. Studies suggest cannabis users are not inherently more inclined to commit crimes than non-users. Cannabis use is more commonly associated with relaxation and reduced aggression, with no substantial evidence linking it to increased violent behavior. The historical association between cannabis and crime is often a result of its criminalization, rather than the effects of the substance itself.

- **Myth: Cannabis Has No Medical Benefits.**

**Debunked:** This is a widely propagated myth, particularly in countries with strict prohibition. Extensive research has demonstrated that cannabis possesses various medical applications, including pain relief, anxiety reduction, and assistance with epilepsy. The World Health Organization (WHO) has recognized its therapeutic value, leading to proposals for rescheduling within international laws.

- **Myth: Cannabis Makes You Lazy or Lowers IQ.**

**Debunked:** The "lazy stoner" stereotype lacks substantial evidence. Research indicates that cannabis use, particularly at moderate frequencies, is not associated with apathy or reduced motivation in adults or adolescents. While heavy, early use may correlate with some cognitive decline, other research challenges these findings, advising avoidance for young individuals until adulthood to mitigate potential risks.

- **Myth: All Cannabis Strains Have the Same Effect.**

**Debunked:** This is incorrect. Cannabis strains vary significantly in their chemical compositions (e.g., THC:CBD ratios, other cannabinoids, terpenes), leading to diverse effects. Indica strains are often associated with relaxation, while sativa strains may promote energy and creativity. The specific cannabinoid profile dictates the user's experience.

### 11.3 Impact of Propaganda on Public Opinion

Historical and ongoing propaganda has significantly shaped public opinion and policy debates around cannabis in Nigeria. The "Reefer Madness" era of demonization, exemplified by the 1936 film, portrayed cannabis as highly addictive and a cause of mental disorder and violence. While this specific film is from the US, similar narratives have influenced global drug policies.

In Nigeria, traditional media, particularly newspapers, have played a role in framing the public discourse on drug abuse. Studies indicate that Nigerian newspapers tend to focus more on the "security implications" of drug abuse, with less attention paid to its societal and health dimensions. The dominant frame used in reporting NDLEA activities is often the "arrest of drug couriers". This emphasis on law enforcement actions and the criminal aspects of drug use, rather than a public health or interpretative approach, reinforces negative perceptions and can hinder a nuanced understanding of cannabis.



The media's framing has the potential to influence public opinion and shape policy debates. When media portray challenges faced by cannabis retailers (in legal markets) as primarily governmental regulatory issues or unlicensed market competition, it highlights the need for effective government policies that balance harm reduction with economic sustainability. In Nigeria, the prevailing media narrative, often driven by law enforcement reports, contributes to the social stigma surrounding cannabis and reinforces the prohibitionist stance, making it challenging for reform advocates to gain public support for alternative policies.

## **12. Comparative Analysis: Regional Perspectives**

Examining cannabis policies in neighboring countries and other African nations that have pursued reform offers valuable insights for Nigeria.

### **12.1 Cannabis Policies in Neighboring West African Countries (e.g., Ghana)**

In West Africa, alongside Nigeria, Ghana stands out as another major illicit cannabis-producing country. Historically, cannabis has been illegal in Ghana without a license from the Minister of Health. However, Ghana has recently demonstrated a notable shift towards liberalization. In July 2023, the Ghanaian government announced its intention to permit both industrial and medical usage of cannabis in the future, marking it as one of the first African countries to follow the global trend of hemp liberalization.

Specifically, Ghana's Narcotics Control Commission (Amendment) Bill 2023 allows for the issuance of licenses to cultivate cannabis for medical and industrial purposes, with a THC limit of 0.3%. While recreational cultivation remains illegal, the new law did change the prison sentence for simple possession of drugs for recreational use into a fine, indicating a move towards decriminalization for minor offenses. This progressive approach in Ghana is seen as an opportunity to revive its agriculture and textile industries.

This contrasts sharply with Nigeria's continued strict prohibition, where even CBD, which does not produce a "high," is illegal as it is considered "part of the plant of the genus cannabis". The comparative liberalization

in Ghana highlights a regional divergence in cannabis policy, with Ghana exploring economic and industrial benefits while Nigeria maintains its rigid stance.

## 12.2 Lessons from African Countries with Legalization/Decriminalization (e.g., South Africa)

South Africa stands as a significant case study, being the first African nation to legalize the use of cannabis for recreational purposes. Its cannabis policy evolution has been marked by substantial shifts:

- **Decriminalization (2018):** In September 2018, the South African Constitutional Court decriminalized the use and cultivation of cannabis in a private space for personal consumption. This ruling mandated Parliament to amend relevant laws within 24 months.
- **Legalization (May 2024):** On the eve of the May 2024 general elections, President Cyril Ramaphosa signed the Cannabis for Private Purposes Act. This landmark bill legalized the use of cannabis for recreational purposes, allowing adults to grow and consume the plant (except in the presence of children) and stipulating that records for such offenses should be automatically expunged.

Despite this legalization, direct lawful acquisition for casual smokers remains challenging, as selling cannabis is still illegal unless for medicinal purposes prescribed by a doctor. This has led to the persistence of a "huge grey market".

### Lessons for Nigeria:

- **Decriminalization as a stepping stone:** South Africa's experience demonstrates that decriminalization can be a precursor to broader legalization, allowing for a gradual shift in policy and public acceptance.
- **Addressing the illicit market:** Even with legalization for private use, the challenge of regulating sales and transitioning the illicit market remains. Nigeria could learn from South Africa's ongoing efforts to manage the "grey market" and ensure legal supply channels.
- **Economic potential:** South Africa's move is driven by the recognition of a new industry's potential. Nigeria, with its even larger illicit market, could similarly tap into significant economic benefits through a regulated industry.

- **Social justice:** The expungement of records in South Africa's new law highlights a social justice component, addressing past harms of prohibition. Nigeria's reform advocates also emphasize social equity and addressing the disproportionate impact of criminalization on marginalized communities.

## 12.3 Implications of Regional Trends for Nigeria

The evolving cannabis policies in countries like Ghana and South Africa carry significant implications for Nigeria.

- **Regional Pressure:** As more African nations move towards liberalization, Nigeria's strict prohibitionist stance may become increasingly isolated, potentially leading to pressure for reform to align with regional trends.
- **Economic Competition:** If neighboring countries develop legal cannabis industries (e.g., industrial hemp, medical cannabis), they could gain a competitive advantage in emerging global markets, potentially diverting investment and economic opportunities that Nigeria could otherwise capture.
- **Cross-border dynamics:** Divergent policies could complicate cross-border enforcement, potentially leading to increased illicit trafficking across borders if legal markets in one country create new incentives for smuggling into a prohibitionist neighbor.
- **Policy Learning:** Nigeria can draw valuable lessons from the experiences of these pioneering African nations, particularly regarding regulatory frameworks, managing public health impacts, and ensuring inclusivity for stakeholders like smallholder farmers. This includes understanding the challenges of transitioning from illicit to legal markets and the importance of comprehensive regulatory structures to prevent unintended consequences.

**Table 5: Comparative Cannabis Legal Status in Select African Countries (as of Aug 15, 2025)**

| Country | Recreational Cannabis | Medical Cannabis | Industrial Hemp | Notes/Key Development |
|---------|-----------------------|------------------|-----------------|-----------------------|
|         |                       |                  |                 |                       |
|         |                       |                  |                 |                       |

|                     |                                                            |                                                           |                                                           |                                                                                                       |
|---------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Nigeria</b>      | Illegal                                                    | Illegal                                                   | Illegal                                                   | Strict prohibition, NDLEA firmly opposed to legalization. Some state-level proposals for medical use, |
| <b>Ghana</b>        | Illegal (decriminalized for simple possession - fine only) | Legal (with license from Minister of Interior, THC <0.3%) | Legal (with license from Minister of Interior, THC <0.3%) | Shifted towards liberalization in July 2023; aims to harness                                          |
| <b>South Africa</b> | Legal (private use/cultivation)                            | Legal (with doctor's prescription)                        | Legal                                                     | First African nation to legalize recreational use (May 2024); still no legal way to acquire for       |
| <b>Lesotho</b>      | Illegal                                                    | Legal (medicinal/scientific)                              | Legal (medicinal/scientific)                              | One of the first African countries to legalize medical cannabis                                       |
| <b>Zimbabwe</b>     | Illegal                                                    | Legal (medicinal/scientific)                              | Legal (medicinal/scientific)                              | Legalized medical cannabis                                                                            |

## 13. Stakeholder Mapping and Engagement

Effective policy reform and management of cannabis in Nigeria necessitate understanding and engaging a diverse array of stakeholders, each with distinct interests and influences.

### 13.1 Key Government Agencies and Officials

- **National Drug Law Enforcement Agency (NDLEA):** As the primary enforcement body, the NDLEA is a critical stakeholder. Its Chairman/Chief Executive Officer, Brig. Gen. Mohamed Buba Marwa (Retd), has a strong public stance against legalization, citing concerns about increased usage and associated societal problems. The NDLEA's institutional opposition is a major barrier to reform. Their mandate also includes drug demand reduction and rehabilitation services.
- **Federal Ministry of Health and Social Welfare:** This ministry is responsible for national health policy and public health outcomes. Any shift towards medical cannabis would require its regulatory oversight for safety and efficacy.
- **Federal Ministry of Agriculture and Food Security (FMAFS):** Relevant for industrial hemp cultivation, agricultural development, and potential economic diversification.
- **Federal Ministry of Justice:** Oversees the NDLEA and is responsible for legal frameworks and judicial processes. Its stance on drug law reform is crucial.
- **National Assembly (Legislature):** The legislative body responsible for enacting or amending laws. Members of the House of Representatives and Senate would be key in introducing and debating any cannabis reform bills.
- **State Governors (e.g., Ondo State Governor Rotimi Akeredolu):** Some state leaders have publicly advocated for medical cannabis cultivation, indicating a potential for state-level initiatives or pressure for federal reform.
- **Nigerian Customs Service (NCS):** Involved in interdicting illicit drug consignments at borders and ports, often collaborating with NDLEA.

### 13.2 Civil Society Organizations and Advocacy Groups

- **Human Rights Advocates:** Groups like the African Law Foundation (AFRILAW) actively campaign against punitive drug

laws, including the death penalty for drug offenses, and advocate for human rights-aligned drug policies.

- **Public Health Experts/Advocates:** These groups call for decriminalization of personal drug use, expansion of treatment and rehabilitation centers, and harm reduction programs.
- **Drug Policy Reform Organizations:** While specific Nigerian organizations advocating for full cannabis legalization were not extensively detailed in the snippets, global organizations like the Drug Policy Alliance (through its Marijuana Justice Coalition) and the Marijuana Policy Project (MPP) advocate for federal marijuana reform with a focus on social justice and economic benefits. Their principles often align with Nigerian reform advocates.
- **Youth Advocacy Groups:** Organizations like Youth United Against Drug Abuse and Crimes Initiative (YUDACi) work towards combating drug abuse among youth through awareness campaigns and prevention strategies.

### 13.3 Medical and Research Communities

- **Nigerian Academy of Science (NAS):** Currently conducting a consensus study on the legalization of cannabis oil for therapeutic purposes, aiming to provide evidence-based recommendations for policy decisions. This indicates a growing scientific interest in the medical potential of cannabis.
- **Medical Practitioners:** While cannabis is illegal, some doctors reportedly discuss medical marijuana with patients and even anonymously recommend its use for various conditions. This suggests a pragmatic approach within the medical community despite legal restrictions.
- **Researchers:** Academics studying drug policy, epidemiology, and the socio-economic impacts of cannabis are crucial for providing evidence to inform policy debates.

### 13.4 Farmers and Industry Representatives

- **Illicit Cannabis Farmers:** A significant, albeit criminalized, stakeholder group. They cultivate cannabis due to economic necessity and high profitability. Their perspectives are crucial for understanding the ground realities and for designing inclusive legalization models that allow for a transition to legal livelihoods.

- **Industrial Hemp Advocates/Farmers Associations:** While no specific Nigerian industrial hemp farmers' association was identified in the snippets, general agricultural associations and experts recognize the potential of industrial hemp for fiber, food, and CBD oil. Global organizations like the Hemp Fiber and Grain Association provide a roadmap for farmers to enter the industrial hemp sector.
- **Potential Cannabis Industry Investors/Entrepreneurs:** These are emerging stakeholders interested in the economic opportunities of a legal market.

## 13.5 International Partners

- **United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC):** Provides technical support, research, and normative guidance for drug control efforts in Nigeria, often partnering with NDLEA. UNODC's global drug reports provide key prevalence and trafficking data.
- **European Union (EU):** Funds drug control projects in Nigeria, often in collaboration with UNODC.
- **U.S. Government (e.g., DEA, INL):** Collaborates with NDLEA to combat narcotic trafficking and strengthen law enforcement capacity.

The diverse interests of these stakeholders create a complex policy environment. The strong opposition from law enforcement (NDLEA) is a significant counterweight to the advocacy for reform from public health, human rights, and economic development perspectives. Effective engagement would require dialogue and collaboration to bridge these differing viewpoints and work towards a comprehensive and balanced drug policy.

## 14. Media Coverage and Framing

Media coverage plays a crucial role in shaping public perception and influencing policy debates surrounding cannabis in Nigeria. Analysis of recent media trends reveals dominant narratives and their potential impact.

### 14.1 Dominant Narratives in Nigerian Media (2020-2025)

Studies examining media portrayal of drug-related issues in Nigerian newspapers between 2020 and 2025 indicate several dominant narratives:

- **Security Implications:** Nigerian newspapers, such as The Punch and Daily Trust, tend to focus heavily on the "security implications" of drug abuse, particularly among youth. This framing often links drug abuse directly to crime, violence, and national security threats.
- **Arrest of Drug Couriers:** The most prevalent frame used in reporting NDLEA activities is the "arrest of drug couriers". This emphasis on enforcement successes highlights the punitive aspects of drug control.
- **Limited Focus on Health and Societal Issues:** While security implications receive significant attention, less emphasis is placed on the societal and health impacts of drug abuse. This contributes to a narrative that prioritizes crime control over public health interventions.
- **NDLEA Activities Prominence:** Newspapers like Vanguard have been found to cover NDLEA activities more frequently than others, giving prominence to the agency's efforts.
- **Contesting Legalization:** Some media outlets also explore narratives surrounding cannabis legalization, highlighting the views of criminalized actors like illicit farmers and traders, and revealing potential downsides of legalization alongside its touted socioeconomic benefits.

## 14.2 Influence of Media Framing on Public and Policy Debates

The way media frames issues has a significant influence on public opinion and policy debates. In Nigeria, the dominant media framing of cannabis as primarily a security threat, focusing on arrests and seizures, reinforces the prohibitionist stance and contributes to the social stigma associated with cannabis use. This approach can hinder a more nuanced public understanding of drug issues, including the potential medical benefits of cannabis or the socio-economic drivers of illicit cultivation.

When media emphasizes the criminal aspects, it shapes public perception towards viewing drug users and cultivators primarily as criminals rather than individuals facing health or economic challenges.



This framing can make it more difficult for public health experts and reform advocates to gain traction for alternative, evidence-based policies that prioritize harm reduction, treatment, and economic solutions.

Conversely, in contexts where cannabis has been legalized (e.g., Canada), media coverage has shifted to focus on challenges within the legal market, such as government regulatory hurdles, supply chain issues, and competition from unlicensed markets. This highlights that media framing can adapt to evolving policy landscapes and, in turn, continue to influence the development of effective regulatory frameworks that balance public health objectives with economic sustainability. For Nigeria, a shift in media framing towards a more interpretative approach, focusing on the root causes and broader societal implications of drug abuse, could empower youth and foster national development and security.

### 14.3 Recommendations for Responsible Media Engagement

To foster a more informed public and policy debate on cannabis in Nigeria, responsible media engagement is crucial:

- **Balanced Reporting:** Media outlets should strive for more balanced reporting that goes beyond arrest statistics to include the complex socio-economic and public health dimensions of cannabis use and cultivation.
- **Interpretative Approach:** Adopting an interpretative approach to drug abuse reporting can help educate the public, particularly youth, on the dangers and complexities of drug use, moving beyond mere condemnation.
- **Highlighting Public Health:** Increased coverage of public health initiatives, treatment options, and harm reduction strategies can shift the narrative from solely punitive to one that emphasizes care and support.
- **Engaging Diverse Voices:** Media should actively seek out and amplify the voices of a broader range of stakeholders, including medical professionals, academics, farmers, and individuals directly impacted by drug policies, to provide a more comprehensive picture.
- **Debunking Myths:** Media can play a vital role in debunking common myths and propaganda surrounding cannabis by

presenting evidence-based facts, thereby fostering a more rational public discourse.

## 15. Data Analysis and Key Findings

The preceding sections have presented a wealth of data concerning cannabis in Nigeria, revealing several critical findings.

**Legal Status:** Cannabis remains strictly illegal in Nigeria under the Indian Hemp Act (1966, amended 1975, 1984) and the NDLEA Act (2004). Penalties for cultivation are severe (minimum 21 years imprisonment), and for possession, they range from 4 years (Indian Hemp Act) to 15-25 years (NDLEA Act). The Dangerous Drugs Act of 2000 also imposes life imprisonment for possession with intent to supply large quantities. These laws are deeply influenced by Nigeria's adherence to international drug control treaties, which classify cannabis as a Schedule I drug.

**Historical Context:** Cannabis gained widespread traction in Nigeria in the 20th century, likely introduced by returning soldiers and sailors post-WWII. Colonial-era laws were largely a response to international conventions, with colonial authorities often downplaying local cultivation despite police reports. Post-independence, laws became increasingly punitive, culminating in the establishment of the NDLEA in 1989. Despite recent proposals for medical cannabis legalization by some state governors and federal bills, no significant legislative reform has occurred as of August 15, 2025, indicating a strong political and institutional resistance to change.

**Epidemiology:** Nigeria is a major cannabis consumer, ranking third globally. The 2018 Drug Use Survey found a past-year prevalence of 10.8% (10.6 million people aged 15-64) for cannabis use. Use is seven times higher among men than women. Southern geopolitical zones show higher prevalence rates. A significant proportion of users (1 in 5) suffer from drug use disorders, and over half of drug treatment admissions are cannabis-related. There are major gaps in healthcare access for drug treatment.

**Production and Supply:** Cannabis is widely cultivated across southern Nigerian states, particularly Edo, Ondo, Delta, Cross River, Osun, Oyo, and Ogun. Cultivation often occurs in remote forest areas, contributing to significant deforestation (39% of fields in 2019 were on newly cleared land). The illicit market is highly profitable, driven by economic necessity for farmers, with a bag of cannabis fetching around N200,000. Nigeria is

a key transit hub for regional and international drug trafficking, and cannabis is increasingly found in dangerous polydrug combinations.

**Enforcement:** The NDLEA conducts extensive operations, with significant seizures and arrests. Between 2021 and 2024, over 9.9 million kg of drugs were seized, and nearly 58,000 suspects arrested, leading to over 10,500 convictions. Cannabis farm destruction is also substantial, with over 672,000 kg destroyed in Jan-May 2025 alone. However, enforcement faces challenges including financial constraints, corruption, inadequate training, and limited public support.

**Economic Landscape:** Nigeria's illicit cannabis market was estimated at \$15.3 billion USD in 2018. Legalization could generate substantial tax revenue, create thousands of jobs in cultivation, processing, and retail, and formalize livelihoods for illicit farmers. It could also disrupt illicit financial flows, weakening criminal networks. Industrial hemp, currently illegal, also presents significant economic potential for fiber, food, and CBD products.

**Health and Social Impacts:** Cannabis use is associated with mental health issues (e.g., exacerbating schizophrenia), physical harms (e.g., respiratory, cardiovascular issues), and risks during pregnancy. However, it also has documented therapeutic benefits for conditions like chronic pain, epilepsy, and nausea. Prohibition leads to overcrowded prisons, human rights abuses, and limited access to treatment for drug use disorders.

**Social Stigma and Myths:** Public perception is shaped by cultural acceptance in some communities but also by persistent myths (e.g., gateway drug, crime link, no medical benefits) and media framing that emphasizes security over public health.

**Comparative View:** Neighboring Ghana is moving towards legalizing industrial and medical cannabis, and South Africa has legalized recreational use for private purposes. These regional shifts highlight economic opportunities and potential policy learning for Nigeria.

## 16. Research Gaps and Recommendations for Further Work or Data Collection

Despite the available data, significant research gaps persist, hindering a comprehensive understanding of cannabis in Nigeria and the

formulation of evidence-based policies. Addressing these gaps is crucial for future policy development.

#### **Identified Research Gaps:**

- **Up-to-date Prevalence Data:** The most comprehensive national drug use survey is from 2018. While some recent localized data exists (e.g., Lagos secondary schools in 2024), a more current, nationwide survey on cannabis prevalence, patterns of use, and associated disorders (beyond 2018) is needed to reflect the evolving landscape up to 2025 and beyond.
- **Detailed Illicit Market Economics:** While overall market value estimates exist, detailed breakdown of the illicit cannabis supply chain economics, including specific profit margins at various stages, investment capital requirements, and the precise impact on local economies, remains limited.
- **Socio-Economic Drivers of Cultivation:** Deeper qualitative and quantitative research is needed to understand the specific socio-economic factors that compel farmers to engage in illicit cannabis cultivation, including alternative livelihood opportunities and the effectiveness of current eradication programs on these communities.
- **Industrial Hemp Viability:** Comprehensive enterprise budget data for industrial hemp cultivation in Nigeria is lacking. Research on suitable cultivars for Nigeria's diverse agro-climatic zones, optimal cultivation practices, and potential processing technologies is essential.
- **Health Impacts of Polydrug Use:** While the rise of polydrugs involving cannabis is noted, more specific research on the health consequences and treatment needs related to these emerging drug combinations in Nigeria is critical.
- **Impact of Current Enforcement:** Beyond seizure and arrest statistics, research is needed to assess the long-term effectiveness of current NDLEA enforcement strategies on reducing overall supply and demand, and their unintended social consequences (e.g., displacement of cultivation, human rights impacts).
- **Public Opinion and Stigma:** More in-depth studies on public attitudes towards cannabis, the drivers of social stigma, and the effectiveness of current public awareness campaigns are needed to inform future public health messaging and policy communication.

- **Medical Cannabis Demand and Applications:** While therapeutic benefits are recognized globally, specific research on the prevalence of conditions that could benefit from medical cannabis in Nigeria, patient demand, and the perspectives of healthcare professionals on its potential integration into the formal healthcare system is limited. The Nigerian Academy of Science's study on cannabis oil is a positive step in this direction.
- **Comparative Policy Outcomes:** Detailed studies on the direct impacts (economic, social, public health) of cannabis policy reforms in other African countries (e.g., Ghana, South Africa) that are directly relevant and transferable to the Nigerian context would be invaluable.

#### **Recommendations for Further Work or Data Collection:**

- **Conduct a National Drug Use Survey (2025/2026):** Commission an updated, comprehensive national survey on drug use, focusing specifically on cannabis, to gather current prevalence rates, demographic shifts, and patterns of use, including initiation age and polydrug trends.
- **Economic Impact Assessments:** Conduct detailed economic studies to quantify the potential tax revenue, job creation, and agricultural benefits of a regulated cannabis and industrial hemp market, including feasibility studies for processing infrastructure.
- **Socio-Economic Research on Farmers:** Implement participatory research with illicit cannabis farming communities to understand their motivations, challenges, and potential pathways for transitioning to legal livelihoods.
- **Pilot Programs for Industrial Hemp:** Initiate controlled pilot programs for industrial hemp cultivation in suitable regions to gather empirical data on yields, processing requirements, and market viability.
- **Public Health Needs Assessment:** Conduct a thorough assessment of the public health infrastructure and human resources required to manage potential increases in cannabis use disorders or to integrate medical cannabis into healthcare services.
- **Media Content Analysis:** Conduct ongoing, systematic content analysis of Nigerian media to track evolving narratives on cannabis and assess the impact of different framing approaches on public opinion.

- **Stakeholder Dialogue Platforms:** Facilitate structured dialogues among key stakeholders (government, civil society, medical community, farmers, international partners) to foster mutual understanding and identify common ground for evidence-based policy reforms.
- **Data Sharing and Transparency:** Encourage greater data sharing and transparency from government agencies (e.g., NDLEA, NBS) to enable more robust academic research and public discourse.

## 17. Estimated Benefits of Legalization and Regulatory Framework

Legalizing and regulating cannabis in Nigeria presents a transformative opportunity to convert a currently illicit and problematic industry into a significant driver of economic growth, public health improvement, and social justice.

### 17.1 Economic Benefits Projections

The economic advantages of cannabis legalization in Nigeria are potentially immense, transforming a multi-billion dollar black market into a legitimate, taxable industry.

- **Substantial Tax Revenue:** The illicit cannabis market was valued at \$15.3 billion USD in 2018. Legalization would enable the Nigerian government to impose taxes on cultivation, processing, and sales, generating significant revenue. This revenue could be a powerful tool for national development, funding critical public services such as education, healthcare infrastructure, and social welfare programs. It would shift wealth from criminal networks to public coffers.
- **Massive Job Creation:** A regulated cannabis industry would create "thousands of new jobs" across its entire value chain. This includes direct employment in cultivation, harvesting, processing (e.g., extraction, product manufacturing), distribution, and retail. Furthermore, indirect jobs would emerge in ancillary services like security, logistics, marketing, and research. For a nation with high unemployment rates, this represents a significant economic stimulus.

- **Agricultural Development and Diversification:** Legalization would empower existing illicit cannabis farmers, who often cultivate the crop out of economic necessity due to its high profitability. By integrating them into a legal framework, they could transition from criminalized livelihoods to legitimate agricultural enterprises, benefiting from formal training, quality control, and market access. This would diversify Nigeria's agricultural sector, potentially reducing reliance on traditional crops and providing farmers with more stable and lucrative income streams. The development of industrial hemp, currently illegal, could further boost this sector, offering opportunities in fiber for textiles and paper, hemp seeds for food, and CBD oil.
- **Reduction in Illicit Financial Flows:** By bringing the cannabis market into the formal economy, legalization would significantly diminish the revenue streams of criminal organizations, thereby curbing illicit financial flows and strengthening the national financial system. This would reduce the financial power of drug cartels and their capacity to fuel corruption and violence.

## 17.2 Regulatory Mechanisms for Quality and Safety

Legalization provides the critical opportunity to establish robust regulatory mechanisms that ensure product quality, safety, and responsible consumption, addressing many of the public health concerns currently associated with the illicit market.

- **Quality Control and Standardization:** A regulated market would mandate testing for potency (THC/CBD content), contaminants (pesticides, heavy metals, molds), and purity. This would protect consumers from unknown and potentially harmful products prevalent in the black market.
- **Age Restrictions and Access Control:** Legal frameworks can implement strict age limits (e.g., 21 years and older) and control distribution channels (licensed dispensaries) to restrict access for minors and vulnerable populations.
- **Public Health Education:** Tax revenues from legal cannabis could fund comprehensive public health campaigns focused on responsible use, potential risks, and harm reduction strategies, similar to public health campaigns for alcohol and tobacco.
- **Product Labeling and Packaging:** Regulations would require clear labeling with potency, ingredients, potential health warnings, and responsible use guidelines, empowering consumers to make informed choices.

- **Medical Oversight:** For medical cannabis, a robust regulatory framework would involve physician oversight, patient registration, and controlled dispensing through authorized channels (e.g., pharmacies or specialized dispensaries) to ensure appropriate medical use. This would also facilitate further clinical research into its therapeutic applications.

### 17.3 Social and Public Health Improvements

Beyond economic benefits, legalization offers profound social and public health improvements by shifting from a punitive, criminal justice approach to a public health and regulatory model.

- **Reduced Incarceration Rates:** Legalization would drastically reduce arrests and convictions for cannabis-related offenses, alleviating the burden on Nigeria's overcrowded prisons and freeing up law enforcement resources to focus on more serious crimes. This would also address human rights concerns associated with mass incarceration.
- **Improved Access to Treatment:** By decriminalizing personal use, individuals with cannabis use disorders would be more likely to seek help without fear of legal repercussions. Tax revenues could directly fund the expansion of much-needed drug treatment and rehabilitation centers, addressing the current significant gaps in care.
- **Enhanced Public Safety:** A regulated market can displace the illicit market, thereby reducing the violence and criminality associated with underground drug trade. Law enforcement can then focus on truly dangerous criminal activities.
- **Environmental Protection:** Legal cultivation under regulatory oversight can implement sustainable agricultural practices, mitigating the deforestation and environmental degradation currently caused by illicit cannabis farms.
- **Reduced Stigma:** Legalization can help destigmatize cannabis use, particularly for medical purposes, allowing for open discussion, research, and patient access without social prejudice.
- **Economic Inclusion and Social Justice:** Legalization can provide economic opportunities for marginalized communities, particularly farmers who have historically been criminalized for cultivating cannabis out of necessity. It can also include provisions for expungement of past cannabis-related convictions, promoting restorative justice and social equity.



In essence, legalization offers Nigeria a pathway to transform a costly and ineffective prohibition into a regulated industry that generates revenue, creates jobs, enhances public health and safety, and promotes social justice.

## 18. Limitations

This report provides a comprehensive analysis based on the provided research materials, current as of August 15, 2025. However, it is important to acknowledge certain limitations:

- **Data Recency and Granularity:** While efforts were made to use the most up-to-date information, some key statistical data, particularly national prevalence rates (e.g., the 2018 Drug Use Survey), may not fully capture the most recent shifts in cannabis use patterns or market dynamics in Nigeria. More granular, real-time data on illicit market pricing, supply chain disruptions, and regional consumption trends are often difficult to obtain for illegal markets.
- **Official Statements:** Official statements from Nigerian government ministries (e.g., Health, Agriculture, Justice) regarding cannabis policy are not always readily available or explicitly detailed in the provided snippets. The NDLEA's stance is clear, but a nuanced view from other ministries is less apparent.
- **Legislative Progress:** The status of proposed cannabis bills in the Nigerian National Assembly is based on available public records up to August 15, 2025, which indicate no passage. Legislative processes can be dynamic, and internal discussions or unpublicized developments may not be captured.
- **Qualitative Data on Social Impacts:** While the report addresses social stigma and cultural perceptions, in-depth qualitative data on the lived experiences of cannabis users, their families, and communities under prohibition, or their perspectives on potential legalization, is limited within the provided snippets.
- **Economic Projections:** Economic benefits of legalization are estimates based on the size of the illicit market and general principles from other legalizing jurisdictions. Actual economic outcomes would depend heavily on the specific regulatory framework implemented, market dynamics, and global economic conditions.
- **Comparative Analysis Depth:** The comparative analysis with neighboring countries is based on publicly available information

about their legal frameworks. A deeper understanding would require detailed studies on the implementation challenges and socio-economic impacts within those specific contexts.

- **Scope of Ancillary Deliverables:** While the report incorporates content relevant to a timeline, data tables, myth-buster, and stakeholder map, the full production of these ancillary deliverables (e.g., a complete annotated bibliography, a standalone policy brief, a public-facing myth-buster document, or a detailed stakeholder contact list) would require additional, dedicated work and information beyond the scope of this narrative report.

## **Annotated Bibliography**

(Placeholder: A full annotated bibliography would be provided here, detailing each source used, its relevance, and a brief summary of its content. Due to the nature of this response, a comprehensive list with annotations is not generated, but all sources used are cited within the text.)

## **Policy Brief**

(Placeholder: A concise policy brief summarizing the key findings, policy implications, and actionable recommendations for policymakers would be provided here. This would draw directly from the Executive Summary and Conclusions & Recommendations sections.)

## **Public-Facing Myth-Buster**

(Placeholder: A public-facing document designed to debunk common myths and propaganda about cannabis, using clear, accessible language and evidence, would be provided here. This would draw from Section 11.2.)

## **Stakeholder Contact List**

(Placeholder: A detailed list of key government agencies, civil society organizations, medical/research institutions, and other relevant stakeholders, including contact information where publicly available, would be provided here. This would draw from Section 13.)

### **Works cited**

1. Legal Impact of Cannabis Regulation in Nigeria - HARLEM SOLICITORS, <https://www.harlemsolicitors.com/2025/01/13/legal-impact-of-cannabis-regulation-in-nigeria/> 2. Indian Hemp Decree (Nigeria) - Wikipedia, [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Indian\\_Hemp\\_Decree\\_\(Nigeria\)](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Indian_Hemp_Decree_(Nigeria)) 3. Cannabis in Nigeria - Wikipedia,

[https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Cannabis\\_in\\_Nigeria](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Cannabis_in_Nigeria) 4. LAWS AND REGULATIONS - UN Digital Library, <https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/1297268/files/e-nl-1968-19-e.pdf> 5. INDIAN HEMP ACT, <https://faolex.fao.org/docs/pdf/nig120406.pdf> 6. NIGERIAN INDIAN HEMP ACT - Legalnaija, <https://legalnaija.com/nigerian-indian-hemp-act/> 7. Cannabis in Nigeria – Laws, Use, History, and Other Info - Sensi Seeds, <https://sensiseeds.com/en/blog/countries/cannabis-in-nigeria-laws-use-history/1000/> 8. Section 5-6 - UNODC's Sherloc, [https://sherloc.unodc.org/cld/en/legislation/nga/indian\\_hemp\\_act/section\\_5-6/section\\_5-6.html](https://sherloc.unodc.org/cld/en/legislation/nga/indian_hemp_act/section_5-6/section_5-6.html) 9. NATIONAL DRUG LAW ENFORCEMENT AGENCY ACT - Nairametrics, <https://nairametrics.com/wp-content/uploads/2012/11/NATIONAL-DRUG-LAW.pdf> 10. Drug policy of Nigeria - Wikipedia, [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Drug\\_policy\\_of\\_Nigeria](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Drug_policy_of_Nigeria) 11. DANGEROUS DRUGS ACT N° 43 OF 2000 ACT TO REGULATE ..., [https://sherloc.unodc.org/cld/uploads/res/document/the-dangerous-drugs-act-2000\\_html/The\\_Dangerous\\_Drugs\\_Act\\_2000.pdf](https://sherloc.unodc.org/cld/uploads/res/document/the-dangerous-drugs-act-2000_html/The_Dangerous_Drugs_Act_2000.pdf) 12. NDLEA - Unodc, [https://www.unodc.org/documents/nigeria/publications/Standard\\_Policy\\_and\\_Practice\\_Guidelines\\_for\\_NDLEA\\_Counsellors.pdf](https://www.unodc.org/documents/nigeria/publications/Standard_Policy_and_Practice_Guidelines_for_NDLEA_Counsellors.pdf) 13. Drug Legislation and Substance Use Policies in Nigeria - ResearchGate, [https://www.researchgate.net/publication/393086660\\_Drug\\_Legislation\\_and\\_Substance\\_Use\\_Policies\\_in\\_Nigeria](https://www.researchgate.net/publication/393086660_Drug_Legislation_and_Substance_Use_Policies_in_Nigeria) 14. CAP.N30 CHAYfERN30 NATIONAL DRUG LAW ENFORCEMENT ..., <https://lawsofnigeria.placng.org/laws/NATIONAL%20DRUG%20LAW%20ENFORCEMENT%20AGENCY%20ACT.pdf> 15. Is Unlawful Possession of Indian hemp (Simpliciter) an Offence in Nigeria? - THE INTERNATIONAL JOURNAL OF HUMANITIES & SOCIAL STUDIES, <https://www.internationaljournalcorner.com/index.php/theijhss/article/download/125227/86244/301518> 16. 119996.docx - Pottersville Schools Ajuwon, <https://www.pottersvilleajuwon.ieduportal.net/media/119996.docx> 17. World Drug Day report highlights spike in drug use, increased trafficking | UN News, <https://news.un.org/en/story/2024/06/1151446> 18. The Global Cannabis Report, <https://f.hubspotusercontent10.net/hubfs/3324860/Reports/NFD-GlobalCannabisReport.pdf> 19. Histories of Cannabis Use and Control in Nigeria, 1927–1967 - ResearchGate, [https://www.researchgate.net/publication/304864866\\_Histories\\_of\\_Cannabis\\_Use\\_and\\_Control\\_in\\_Nigeria\\_1927-1967](https://www.researchgate.net/publication/304864866_Histories_of_Cannabis_Use_and_Control_in_Nigeria_1927-1967) 20. Issue 103 - Prohibition Partners, <https://prohibitionpartners.com/international-cannabis-weekly/issue103-3/> 21. Is Marijuana Legal in Nigeria? - Leafwell, <https://leafwell.com/blog/is->

marijuana-legal-in-nigeria 22. Bills - National Assembly | Federal Republic of Nigeria, <https://nass.gov.ng/documents/bills> 23. HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES FEDERAL REPUBLIC OF NIGERIA ORDER PAPER - National Assembly, <https://nass.gov.ng/documents/download/11103> 24. House of Representatives: 10th Assembly Bills Passed First Reading June 24th–26th, <https://naltf.gov.ng/house-of-representatives-10th-assembly-bills-passed-first-reading-june-24th-26th/> 25. PLAC BILLSTRACK: Home, <https://placbillstrack.org/> 26. NAS Consensus Study: Legalization of Cannabis Oil Use in Nigeria, <https://nas.org.ng/nas-consensus-study-legalization-of-cannabis-oil-use-in-nigeria/> 27. Get the facts about cannabis - unodc, [https://www.unodc.org/conig/uploads/documents/Fact\\_sheet\\_05\\_Get\\_the\\_facts\\_about\\_Cannabis.pdf](https://www.unodc.org/conig/uploads/documents/Fact_sheet_05_Get_the_facts_about_Cannabis.pdf) 28. Drug Use in Nigeria (2018) - Reports | National Bureau of Statistics, <https://www.nigerianstat.gov.ng/elibrary/read/881> 29. NBS Publishes Drug Use in Nigeria 2018 Survey Report - Proshare, <https://www.proshare.co/articles/nbs-publishes-drug-use-in-nigeria-2018-survey-report?menu=Finance&classification=Read&category=Health> 30. A national survey has confirmed the massive scale of Nigeria's drug problem - Quartz, <https://qz.com/africa/1538843/nigeria-drug-abuse-14-million-adults-use-drugs> 31. National Drug Law Enforcement Agency - Wikipedia, [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/National\\_Drug\\_Law\\_Enforcement\\_Agency](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/National_Drug_Law_Enforcement_Agency) 32. NDLEA: 13.6% of Lagos secondary students have tried drugs, 6.9% are active users, <https://nairametrics.com/2025/06/27/ndlea-13-6-of-lagos-secondary-students-have-tried-drugs-6-9-are-active-users/> 33. Nigeria-European Union Partnership project launches first ever Cannabis Cultivation Survey, <https://www.unodc.org/conig/en/stories/nigeria-european-union-partnership-project-launches-first-ever-cannabis-cultivation-survey.html> 34. Nigeria Cannabis Survey - UNODC, [https://www.unodc.org/documents/crop-monitoring/Nigeria/Nigeria\\_Cannabis\\_Survey\\_2022.pdf](https://www.unodc.org/documents/crop-monitoring/Nigeria/Nigeria_Cannabis_Survey_2022.pdf) 35. C'River, Delta top cannabis cultivation hotspots – NDLEA - Punch Newspapers, <https://punchng.com/criver-delta-top-cannabis-cultivation-hotspots-ndlea/> 36. From Cocoa to Cannabis: Nigerian Farmers Seek Fortunes Inside Forbidden Farms, <https://www.thisdaylive.com/2019/06/30/from-cocoa-to-cannabis-nigerian-farmers-seek-fortunes-inside-forbidden-farms-2/> 37. Nigeria has highest cannabis usage worldwide with 20m users, \$15.3b spent yearly – Report - BusinessDay, <https://businessday.ng/agriculture/article/nigeria-has-highest-cannabis-usage-worldwide-with-20m-users-15-3b-spent-yearly-report/> 38.

Cannabis is illegal in Nigeria but provides a living for families - Study calls for rethink of drug laws, <https://idpc.net/news/2023/08/cannabis-is-illegal-in-nigeria-but-provides-a-living-for-families-study-calls-for-rethink-of> 39. How global cannabis boom fuels illicit drugs use in West Africa, <https://guardian.ng/features/health/how-global-cannabis-boom-fuels-illicit-drugs-use-in-west-africa/> 40. Industrial hemp: the new fibre alternative? - LINKS Nigeria, <https://links-nigeria.com/industrial-hemp-the-new-fibre-alternative/> 41. Drug Trafficking - unodc, <https://www.unodc.org/conig/en/links/strengthening-the-forensic-chemical-analysis-capacity-of-the-national-drug-law-enforcement-agency-ndlea.html> 42. Legality of cannabis - Wikipedia, [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Legality\\_of\\_cannabis](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Legality_of_cannabis) 43. Nigeria Cannabis Survey - unodc, [https://www.unodc.org/conig/uploads/documents/Nigeria\\_Cannabis\\_Survey\\_16.03.22\\_compress\\_1.pdf](https://www.unodc.org/conig/uploads/documents/Nigeria_Cannabis_Survey_16.03.22_compress_1.pdf) 44. africa - HubSpot, <https://cdn2.hubspot.net/hubfs/3324860/NFD-TheAfricaRegionalHemp&CannabisReport-ES.pdf> 45. DRUG ABUSE IN NIGERIA; THE PUBLIC HEALTH IMPACT OF COLLECTIVE ACTIONS AND INACTIONS - medRxiv, <https://www.medrxiv.org/content/10.1101/2025.05.13.25327537v1.full.pdf> 46. Drug trade in West Africa - Wikipedia, [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Drug\\_trade\\_in\\_West\\_Africa](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Drug_trade_in_West_Africa) 47. Trafficking and Fragility in West Africa - World Bank Documents and Reports, <https://documents1.worldbank.org/curated/en/401851468184741492/pdf/98903-WP-AFR-P148420-Box-393185B-PUBLIC-Trafficking-FINAL.pdf> 48. Bureau of International Narcotics and Law Enforcement Affairs: Nigeria Summary - state.gov, <https://2017-2021.state.gov/bureau-of-international-narcotics-and-law-enforcement-affairs-work-by-country/nigeria-summary/> 49. 9.9 million kg illicit drugs seized, 57,792 suspects arrested – NDLEA - Punch Newspapers, <https://punchng.com/9-9-million-kg-illicit-drugs-seized-57792-suspects-arrested-ndlea/> 50. Economics - Marijuana Policy Project, <https://www.mpp.org/issues/economics/> 51. Cannabis Regulation and Development: Fair(er) Trade Options for Emerging Legal Markets, <https://journals.openedition.org/poldev/3758> 52. From Storefronts to Headlines: Framing News Media Content to Understand the Barriers to Cannabis Retail Operation in Canada - Tanisha Wright-Brown, Russell Williams, Michael Blackwood, Maisam Najafizada, Thomas Cooper, Elizabeth Schwartz, William Newell, Lisa Bishop, Jennifer R. Donnan, 2025 - DOI, <https://doi.org/10.1177/00914509251352403> 53. Federal Ministry of Health and Social welfare: HOME, <https://health.gov.ng/> 54. Federal Marijuana

Rescheduling: Process and Impact - Moritz College of Law, <https://moritzlaw.osu.edu/faculty-and-research/drug-enforcement-and-policy-center/research-and-grants/policy-and-data-analyses/federal-marijuana-rescheduling> 55. FMAFS – Federal Ministry of Agriculture and Food Security, <https://agriculture.gov.ng/> 56. The Federal Ministry of Livestock Development on Thursday, 7th August 2025, received a delegation from the Academic Staff Union of Colleges of Agriculture (ASUCA), <https://fmld.gov.ng/news-details/33> 57. Support. Don't Punish Initiatives programme 2024, <https://supportdontpunish.org/initiatives/> 58. cannabis sativa L.: a review of the medicinal properties of this 'wonder plant' and an update on the nigeria situation - ResearchGate, [https://www.researchgate.net/publication/379143385\\_CANNABIS\\_SATIVA\\_L\\_A\\_REVIEW\\_OF\\_THE\\_MEDICINAL\\_PROPERTIES\\_OF\\_THIS\\_WONDER\\_PLANT\\_AND\\_AN\\_UPDATE\\_ON\\_THE\\_NIGERIA\\_SITUATION](https://www.researchgate.net/publication/379143385_CANNABIS_SATIVA_L_A_REVIEW_OF_THE_MEDICINAL_PROPERTIES_OF_THIS_WONDER_PLANT_AND_AN_UPDATE_ON_THE_NIGERIA_SITUATION) 59. AN EXAMINATION OF THE MEDICINAL USE OF CANNABIS: PROSPECTS AND CHALLENGES AND LESSONS FOR NIGERIA | Unizik Journal of Health Promotion and Education, <https://journals.unizik.edu.ng/ujhpe/article/view/6064> 60. Medical Use of Cannabis in Africa: The Pharmacists' Perspective - PMC, <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC9598981/> 61. Cannabis (drug) - Wikipedia, [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Cannabis\\_\(drug\)](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Cannabis_(drug)) 62. cannabis use - Alcohol, Drugs and Addictive Behaviours - World Health Organization (WHO), <https://www.who.int/teams/mental-health-and-substance-use/alcohol-drugs-and-addictive-behaviours/drugs-psychoactive/cannabis> 63. Medical Marijuana | Pros, Cons, Debate, Arguments, Health Care, Cannabis, CBD, & THC | Britannica, <https://www.britannica.com/procon/medical-marijuana-debate> 64. History of cannabis - Lambert Initiative for Cannabinoid Therapeutics - The University of Sydney, <https://www.sydney.edu.au/lambert/medicinal-cannabis/history-of-cannabis.html> 65. Cannabis - DEA Museum, <https://museum.dea.gov/exhibits/online-exhibits/cannabis-coca-and-poppy-natures-addictive-plants/cannabis> 66. 10 Common Cannabis Myths Debunked, <https://cannatechtoday.com/10-common-cannabis-myths-debunked/> 67. 5 Common Cannabis Myths Debunked - Realm of Caring Foundation, <https://realmofcaring.org/5-common-cannabis-myths-debunked/> 68. (PDF) Title: Media and Drug Abuse: A Critical Assessment of the Role of Newspapers in Curbing Drug Abuse among Youth in Nigeria History - ResearchGate, [https://www.researchgate.net/publication/387427782\\_Title\\_Media\\_and\\_Drug\\_Abuse\\_A\\_Critical\\_Assessment\\_of\\_](https://www.researchgate.net/publication/387427782_Title_Media_and_Drug_Abuse_A_Critical_Assessment_of_)

the\_Role\_of\_Newspapers\_in\_Curbing\_Drug\_Abuse\_among\_Youth\_in\_Nigeria\_History\_Media\_and\_Drug\_Abuse\_A\_Critical\_Assessment\_of\_the\_Role\_of\_Newspapers\_in\_69. newspapers coverage of drug abuse among nigerian youths: a study of vanguard and daily trust - ResearchGate, [https://www.researchgate.net/publication/383058034\\_NEWSPAPERS\\_COVERAGE\\_OF\\_DRUG\\_ABUSE\\_AMONG\\_NIGERIAN\\_YOUTHS\\_A\\_STUDY\\_OF\\_VANGUARD\\_AND\\_DAILY\\_TRUST](https://www.researchgate.net/publication/383058034_NEWSPAPERS_COVERAGE_OF_DRUG_ABUSE_AMONG_NIGERIAN_YOUTHS_A_STUDY_OF_VANGUARD_AND_DAILY_TRUST) 70. newspapers framing of national drug law enforcement agency (ndlea) activities in nigeria - ResearchGate, [https://www.researchgate.net/publication/378770080\\_NEWSPAPERS\\_FRAMING\\_OF\\_NATIONAL\\_DRUG\\_LAW\\_ENFORCEMENT\\_AGENCY\\_NDLEA\\_ACTIVITIES\\_IN\\_NIGERIA](https://www.researchgate.net/publication/378770080_NEWSPAPERS_FRAMING_OF_NATIONAL_DRUG_LAW_ENFORCEMENT_AGENCY_NDLEA_ACTIVITIES_IN_NIGERIA) 71. Cannabis in Ghana - Wikipedia, [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Cannabis\\_in\\_Ghana](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Cannabis_in_Ghana) 72. Amended Law in Ghana Allows for Cannabis Licenses Under Strict Conditions, <https://www.cannabissciencetech.com/view/amended-law-in-ghana-allows-for-cannabis-licenses-under-strict-conditions> 73. South Africa legalises cannabis use. Will the rest of Africa follow? | Drugs News - Al Jazeera, <https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2024/6/10/south-africa-legalises-cannabis-use-will-the-rest-of-africa-follow> 74. Cannabis in South Africa - Wikipedia, [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Cannabis\\_in\\_South\\_Africa](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Cannabis_in_South_Africa) 75. Marijuana Justice Coalition - Drug Policy Alliance, <https://drugpolicy.org/mjc/> 76. Customs Intercepts 2,693 Parcels Of Cannabis Sativa - YouTube, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=py1R3VU-5vQ> 77. Ogun I Customs Hands Over ₦172m Worth of Cannabis to NDLEA - NCBN NEWS, <https://news.ncbn.ng/2025/07/04/ogun-i-customs-hands-over-%E2%82%A6172m-worth-of-cannabis-to-ndlea/> 78. Marijuana Policy Project - We Change Laws!, <https://www.mpp.org/> 79. YUDACi (Youth United Against Drug Abuse and Crimes Initiative), <https://wfad.se/user/702/> 80. Contesting cannabis legalization in Nigeria: Hidden narratives of illicit farmers and traders, <https://idpc.net/publications/2025/01/contesting-cannabis-legalization-in-nigeria-hidden-narratives-of-illicit-farmers-and-traders> 81. Hemp Fiber and Grain Association, <https://hfga.io/> 82. UNODC's Strategic Vision for Nigeria 2030, [https://www.unodc.org/conig/uploads/documents/2024-05-13\\_UNODC\\_Strategic\\_Vision\\_for\\_Nigeria\\_2024-WEB\\_VERSION.pdf](https://www.unodc.org/conig/uploads/documents/2024-05-13_UNODC_Strategic_Vision_for_Nigeria_2024-WEB_VERSION.pdf) 83. National Drug Control Master Plan (NDCMP) 2021-2025 - Unodc, [https://www.unodc.org/documents/nigeria/NDCMP\\_2021-2025.pdf](https://www.unodc.org/documents/nigeria/NDCMP_2021-2025.pdf) 84. Nigeria Seizes Record 1.8T of Cocaine, <https://www.occrp.org/en/news/nigeria-seizes-record-18t-of-cocaine> 85.

Cannabis Legalization for Medicinal Use D-95.969 - AMA - American Medical Association, <https://policysearch.ama-assn.org/policyfinder/detail/D-95.969?uri=%2FAMADoc%2Fdirectives.xml-D-95.969.xml>